

A GRIMOIRE OF THE OLD RELIGIONS · VOL. I

# The Old Norse Grimoire

A window to the old world, gods,
oath & craft

# DEDICATION

For Huginn and Muninn.
While they return to Óðinn each night, may they also return to us as well.

# Contents

**1. Welcome**: Working with the Old Ways · 4–6

**2. The Poems**: what the sources are · 7–10

**3. The Old Norse**: who they were and how we know · 11–14

**4. Nine Realms**: The Gods and Their Kingdoms · 15–20

**5. Rǫgn**: Gods & Ruling Powers · 21–38

**6. Animals**: ravens, wolves, horses, snakes, and eagles · 39–41

**7. Tales**: stories from the old books · 42–44

**8. Vǫlva & Seiðr**: seeress and fate-work · 45–51

**9. Hamingja**: luck, fylgja, and dreams · 52–59

**10. Elves & Dwarfs**: neighbors and smiths · 60–69

**11. Norse Wheel of the Year**: Winter Nights to Midsummer · 70–88

**12. Plants & Trees**: healing plants, food, and trees · 89–104

**13. Liminal Places**: wells that remember · 105–110

**14. Runes**: the letters of the old north · 111–126

**15. Staves**: use them honestly · 127–132

**16. Galdr: Charms**: words in old books · 133–137

**17. Ancestors**: mound-neighbors · 138–143

**18. Oath**: go on reading · 144–150

# Welcome

Working with the Old Ways

*"Givers, hail! A guest is come in: where shall he sit?"*

Hávamál, stanza 2, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Working with the Old Ways

Rest your tired bones and troubled mind. This book shares the old Norse ways, which were about keeping good company with the living, the dead, and the land. It is meant to bring you comfort and a sense of connection with your ancestors. If parts of it do not fit your life or beliefs, leave them behind and keep what helps. I have tried to present these old ways as accurately as the sources allow, and I mark each claim with where it comes from. Use the prompt at the end of each page, and the lined pages, to write, reflect, and build your own practice in whatever way works best for you. Write your answers on a lined page or in a notebook of your own, and date them.

This book mentions plants from folk custom and from medieval medical books, but it does not replace a doctor. Never eat, drink, or apply any plant from these pages based on this book alone. If you forage, go with an experienced guide, check each plant against at least three trusted sources, and take only what you need, leaving most of it behind. For medicinal herbs, I buy from Mountain Rose Herbs: https://mountainroseherbs.com/

**Where this comes from.** Every lore page ends with a short note that says where its ideas come from: a poem, a saga, a stone, a custom, or this book. If a source is late, or scholars disagree, the note says so. Anything described as modern or rebuilt was written for your home and is not an old practice. The main sources are the Poetic Edda, Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, the medieval rune poems, and the sagas listed in Resources.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*What season is it today, outside your actual window? Name three signs.*

## How to say the names

Old Norse names look hard, but a few rules cover most of them. The letter Þ (þ) sounds like "th" in thin. The letter Ð (ð) sounds like "th" in this. An accent mark over a vowel means hold it a little longer. The letter ǫ sounds like the "aw" in law, and j sounds like English "y." The final -r on names like Baldr and Heimdallr is a grammar ending, said roughly like "ur" (BAHL-dur, HAIM-dahl-ur). English spellings usually drop it, which is why you will also see Balder and Heimdall.

**Óðinn** OH-thin
**Þórr** THORR
**Frigg** FRIG
**Freyr** FRAYR
**Freyja** FROY-ah
**Týr** TEER
**Loki** LOH-kee
**Baldr** BAHL-dur
**Heimdallr** HAIM-dahl-ur
**Skaði** SKAH-thee
**Jǫrmungandr** YOR-mun-gahn-dur
**Fenrir** FEN-rir
**Yggdrasill** IG-drah-sil
**Ragnarǫk** RAHG-nah-rok
**Æsir** AY-seer
**Vanir** VAH-neer

These are English-friendly approximations, not a perfect copy of how the Old Norse spoke.

**Where this comes from:** Dr. Jackson Crawford's YouTube channel, on Old Norse pronunciation, simplified for English readers.

# The Poems

What the old sources are

*"...word by word I sought out words..."*

Hávamál, stanza 143, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## The Poems Behind This Book

This book leans on a handful of old texts, and you will meet their names on almost every page. Here is what they are. The Poetic Edda is a collection of about thirty old Icelandic poems about gods and heroes, such as Óðinn, Þórr, and Loki. Most of this book's quotes and stories come from it. Nobody knows who wrote the poems.

The Prose Edda was written by Snorri Sturluson, an Icelandic poet. He wrote it to preserve the style of the old poetry, retelling the myths in plain prose so that poets could keep using it. Many people believe his Christian beliefs influenced his writing, and that may be true to some extent. Still, scholars widely agree that he was genuinely preserving the old Norse stories, and they treat his work as a valuable resource for understanding the past.

You will also see two other kinds of writing. Icelandic sagas are long prose stories about real families and kings. The rune poems are short verses that each describe one rune. The next pages list the poems you will meet most often, so you can look them up whenever a title puzzles you.

**Where this comes from:** The Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, the two collections described on this page.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which poem do you most want to understand? Write its name and why you chose it.*

## Poems of wisdom and the world

**Vǫluspá** (Voluspa), "the seeress's prophecy." A seeress tells Óðinn the story of the world, from its making to its ending at Ragnarǫk and its return.

**Hávamál** (Havamal), "Sayings of the High One." Óðinn's advice on guests, friends, and keeping your wits. It also tells how he won the runes and lists the charms he knows.

**Grímnismál** (Grimnismal), "Grímnir's sayings." Óðinn, in disguise and held captive, names the halls of the gods and the shape of the worlds.

**Vafþrúðnismál** (Vafthrudnismal), "Vafþrúðnir's sayings." Óðinn and a wise giant test each other with questions about the world, its making, and its end.

**Sigrdrífumál** (Sigrdrifumal), "Sigrdrífa's sayings." A valkyrie wakes and teaches the hero Sigurðr runes and counsel.

**The rune poems.** Three medieval poems, Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon, give each rune a short verse of its own.

**Where this comes from:** These poems are in the Poetic Edda and the medieval rune poems.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these poems offers advice you could use this week? Name it and one line of the advice.*

## Poems of the gods

**Lokasenna**, "Loki's quarrel." Loki crashes a feast and insults the gods.

**Þrymskviða** (Thrymskvida), "the lay of Þrymr." A giant steals Þórr's hammer, and Þórr gets it back by dressing as a bride.

**Skírnismál** (Skirnismal), "Skírnir's sayings." Freyr sends his servant Skírnir to win the giant maid Gerðr as his bride. Gods and giants often married in the old stories.

**Hymiskviða** (Hymiskvida), "the lay of Hymir." Þórr visits the giant Hymir for a great kettle and goes fishing for the world serpent.

**Alvíssmál** (Alvissmal), "Alvíss's sayings." Þórr keeps a dwarf answering riddles until the sun comes up.

**Hárbarðsljóð** (Harbardsljod), "Hárbarðr's song." Þórr trades insults with a ferryman, usually thought to be Óðinn in disguise.

**Vǫlundarkviða** (Volundarkvida), "the lay of Vǫlundr." A captive smith takes revenge on a king.

**Hyndluljóð** (Hyndluljod), "the song of Hyndla." Freyja questions a giantess about family lines.

**Where this comes from:** These poems are in the Poetic Edda.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these tales would you read aloud to someone you love? Name it and who you would read it to.*

# The Old Norse

who they were and how we know

*"Moderately wise should each one be, but never over-wise."*

Hávamál, stanza 54, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Who Were the Old Norse

The Old Norse were the people of Scandinavia and the North Atlantic, mostly from about 750 to 1050 CE, a time called the Viking Age. They were not one kingdom. They lived on farms, islands, and fjords in what is now Norway, Denmark, Sweden, and Iceland, and the sea was their main road. They spoke a language we call Old Norse. They wrote it with runes, their own alphabet, which they carved into stone and wood. It is called "Old" because it is the ancestor of Icelandic, Norwegian, Swedish, and Danish. It is now a dead language, meaning no one grows up speaking it, though specialists still study it and some can speak it. Icelandic has changed the least.

We learn about them from two kinds of evidence. The first is what they left behind: runestones, graves, tools, and ships. The second is books. Their stories were not written down until long after the Viking Age, mostly in Iceland. The earlier pages on The Poems introduce the main ones.

What they left behind shows how people actually lived. The stories show what they believed and cared about. Combining the two gives the most well-rounded view of the past.

**Where this comes from:** Runestones and the Viking Age dates come from archaeology. The Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda were copied down centuries later.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Spend half an hour with one short passage from this book. Is it a stone record or a story record?*

## Limitations

No Viking wrote a handbook of belief for us to find. Most of what we know comes from people who were not Vikings, or who lived long after. The Roman writer Tacitus described Germanic peoples around 98 CE, from outside, for a Roman audience. The Arab traveler Ibn Fadlan watched a chieftain's funeral on the Volga River in 922 and wrote it down as a stranger. Icelandic Christians later wrote down the old poems and sagas. They preserved the old stories, though their own beliefs may have shaped how they told them.

Even so, these sources are valuable. Scholars have studied them closely for generations, and together they give a rich picture of Norse myth, belief, and daily life. This book is built on the Old Norse sources themselves.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write one sentence on what you hope this book gives you, and one on what you hope it leaves out.*

## Who kept the knowledge

The old knowledge was not held evenly. Different people kept different parts. The vǫlva (seeress) traveled between farms, was fed and honored, and was asked about the coming season, as Eiríks saga rauða shows. The vitki (rune-master) carved and read runes, as Egill does in Egils saga. The skald (poet) kept memory in verse, and Óðinn's mead of poetry was said to be the source of that gift. The goði (a local leader, in Iceland) kept the gatherings and the law. Households kept the daily customs, who was fed, who was named, and who was remembered.

Each of these has pages in this book. Notice that most of them were learned from someone, by being near them and watching. That is true of most family knowledge too: recipes, songs, names, repairs, and stories.

**Where this comes from:** Eiríks saga rauða for the vǫlva, Egils saga and the Sigrdrífumál for runes, and the Prose Edda for the skald and the mead. The goði appears in the Icelandic sagas.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Who in your own family keeps what: a recipe, a song, a name, a skill? Write one person and what they keep.*

# Nine Realms

The Gods and Their Kingdoms

*"There was in times of old, where Ymir dwelt, nor sand nor sea, nor gelid waves..."*

Vǫluspá, stanza 3, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Creation: fire meets mist

Before anything had a name, there was a gap. The Old Norse called it Ginnungagap, probably "the yawning gap." It was a huge empty space with a world at each end. Múspell (Muspell), the fire world, lay in the south, guarded by the giant Surtr (Surt) with a flaming sword. Niflheimr (Niflheim), the world of mist and cold, lay in the north. Poisonous rivers ran out of Niflheimr, and far from their source they froze into ice.

At first the ice only piled up in the north of the gap, layer on layer. Then sparks and hot air blew north from Múspell, and where the heat touched the ice it melted into drops. From those drops came Ymir, the first giant. Next came a cow named Auðumla (Audumla), who licked the salty ice. Over three days her licking freed a man from it, and his name was Búri (Buri). Later Búri's grandsons, Óðinn (Odin) and his two brothers, killed Ymir and made the world from his body: earth from his flesh, sea from his blood, sky from his skull, mountains from his bones, and trees from his hair.

People came last. According to the Vǫluspá (Voluspa), three gods, Óðinn (Odin), Hœnir (Hoenir), and Lóðurr (Lodur), found two fallen trees on a shore, an ash and an elm. The ash became the first man, Ask, and the elm became the first woman, Embla. Óðinn gave them breath, Hœnir gave them wit, and Lóðurr gave them warmth, and they stood up as the first people.

**Where this comes from:** The creation story is from the Vǫluspá (Voluspa), Vafþrúðnismál (Vafthrudnismal), and Grímnismál (Grimnismal) in the Poetic Edda, and from Snorri's Prose Edda.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write the order of the making from memory: the gap, fire and ice, Ymir, the cow, Búri, Óðinn and his brothers, Ask and Embla.*

# The nine realms at a glance

The Old Norse told of nine realms, or worlds, held together by one great tree, Yggdrasill (Yggdrasil). No single poem lists all nine in one place, so this page gathers them from the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda. The ring-shaped map you may have seen is modern, because the sources give no map.

**Ásgarðr (Asgard)**: home of the Æsir gods, high in the sky, reached by the rainbow bridge Bifrǫst.
**Vanaheimr (Vanaheim)**: home of the Vanir, tied to harvest and plenty.
**Álfheimr (Alfheim)**: home of the light elves, given to Freyr.
**Miðgarðr (Midgard)**: the middle world, where people live.
**Jǫtunheimr (Jotunheim)**: the wild land of the giants.
**Svartálfaheimr (Svartalfheim)**: the underground home of the dwarfs and dark elves, also called Niðavellir in some sources.
**Múspell (Muspell)**: the world of fire, ruled by the giant Surtr.
**Niflheimr (Niflheim)**: the world of ice and fog, with the spring Hvergelmir.
**Hel**: the world of the dead, ruled by a giantess also named Hel.

**Where this comes from:** The realms are named across the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda. Niðavellir is in the Vǫluspá, and Svartálfaheimr is in Snorri's Gylfaginning. The order of this list is this book's.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the nine realms from memory and say what each one is.*

## Yggdrasill: the ash that holds

Yggdrasill is a giant ash tree that holds the nine worlds together. Its three roots reach three wells: Hvergelmir in Niflheimr, the well of Mímir (Mimir), and the well of Urðr (Urd), where the Nornir (Norns) sit and shape fate. A stag feeds on its shoots above. The squirrel Ratatoskr (Ratatosk) runs up and down the trunk carrying messages, and he scolds both ends as he goes.

Yggdrasill is most likely the tree Óðinn hung on when he sacrificed himself for the runes. It has other names. Mjǫtviðr (Mjotvidr) means fate-tree. In the Vǫluspá the seeress remembers it from before it grew, still under the earth, perhaps a seed. Hlautviðr (Hlautvidr) means tree of sacrificial blood. Mímameiðr (Mimameidr) means Mímir's tree, and Mímir's well of wisdom lies at the foot of one of its roots. The Fjǫlsvinnsmál names it.

Read the tree as a picture of how things connect, not as a road map. No source describes a home ritual for it, so this book does not invent one. What you can take home is simple. Everything depends on something else. Roots need water. News travels the trunk like gossip. What you feed at the roots shows up later in the leaves.

Give your roots steady care, such as sleep, regular meals, and honest talk. Notice which roots are dry this week, and water one of them on purpose.

**Where this comes from:** The tree and its tenants are described in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda. The other names come from the Vǫluspá and the Fjǫlsvinnsmál, as taught by Dr. Jackson Crawford.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Draw your life as a tree, with roots, trunk, and crown. Mark three roots that feed you.*

## Where the dead go: Valhǫll (Valhalla), Fólkvangr (Folkvangr), Hel

The dead did not all go to one place. Here is where each place sits.

**Ásgarðr (Asgard), in the sky**: Valhǫll (Valhalla) is Óðinn's hall, roofed with shields and raftered with spears. It takes half of those slain in battle, who feast there as the einherjar until Ragnarǫk. Freyja takes the other half to Fólkvangr (Folkvangr), her own field. The poems do not name its realm. Most retellings put it in Ásgarðr, since Freyja lives among the gods.

**Hel, in the north and below**: Hel's hall, Éljúðnir, keeps those who die of sickness or old age. The road to it runs down and north, over the river Gjǫll, and the hall lies under one root of Yggdrasill. Baldr went there and stayed. Snorri puts Hel inside Niflheimr, so lists differ on whether they are one world or two.

**Nástrǫnd, in the cold north of Hel**: the Corpse Shore, a hall with its doors to the north and venom dripping through the roof. The Vǫluspá places oath-breakers and murderers there. Snorri adds that the worst of the wicked go on from Hel to Niflhel, deeper in Niflheimr.

**Miðgarðr (Midgard), the middle world**: some of the dead stayed near their families. Sagas tell of the dead living on inside their burial mounds, and inside Helgafell, a holy mountain in Iceland. The drowned were said to go to Rán, the sea goddess, in her hall under the waves.

Your memory of someone is a form of care, and it can last longer than any set of beliefs. Keep their name in use. Speak it, write it, and keep one thing they loved in your home.

**Where this comes from:** Valhǫll, Fólkvangr, Hel, and Nástrǫnd are in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda, both copied down late. Snorri is the one who places Hel in Niflheimr. Helgafell and the living dead in mounds are in the Icelandic sagas, and the mounds themselves are known from archaeology.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Name one person who is gone and one thing they cared about.*

## Ragnarǫk: winter without spring

Ragnarǫk (Ragnarok) is the end of the world, told in the Vǫluspá. First comes Fimbulwinter, three winters in a row with no summer between. Families break their promises to one another, and an age of axes begins. The sun darkens and the stars fall. Naglfar, a ship made of dead men's nails, floats free. Heimdallr (Heimdall) blows his horn, and the gods ride out to the plain of Vígríðr (Vigrid).

The poem also says a wolf swallows the moon and spatters the sky and air with blood, that the sun loses its shine, and that the winds blow wild. Set beside eclipses, the lines fit well. In a lunar eclipse the moon turns red and shadowed. In a total solar eclipse the sun loses its light, and the wind and weather can shift as the air cools. Some readers also take the two wolves, Skǫll and Hati, for the moon's north and south nodes, the two points where an eclipse can happen. That is a modern reading.

There they fight. Óðinn falls to the wolf Fenrir. Þórr (Thor) kills the world serpent and falls dead nine steps later. Loki and Heimdallr kill each other. Fire burns the world.

But the poem does not stop there. Earth rises green from the sea a second time. Baldr and Hǫðr (Hodr) return, and Víðarr (Vidar) and Váli (Vali) live on. The golden game pieces the gods once played with are found again in the grass. When something in your life ends, look for what grows after it. Name the ending, then find one small sign of new growth. You can grieve the loss and still look for it.

**Where this comes from:** The doom and the greening are from the Vǫluspá, retold in Snorri's Prose Edda. This book offers no rites for the end of the world.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one ending in your life, and what grew after it, even something small.*

# Rǫgn: Gods & Ruling Powers

The gods and the powers

*"For silence I pray all sacred children, great and small, sons of Heimdall..."*

Vǫluspá, stanza 1, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Æsir and Vanir: The God Tribes

Rǫgn is an old Norse word for the powers: the gods and the forces that rule the world. The gods come in two families. The Æsir include Óðinn, Þórr, and Frigg. They live in Ásgarðr, the high realm in the sky, and they care about oath, battle, and order. The Vanir include Njǫrðr, Freyr, and Freyja. They live in Vanaheimr and care about the sea, the harvest, and plenty. Giants and elves live in other realms and belong to neither family.

The two families once fought a war and then made peace. The next page tells how it ended. Scholars think the story may remember two peoples who later joined together. It comes to us from the Vǫluspá, the seeress's prophecy in the Poetic Edda, and from Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, written around 1220. Both were written down centuries after the Viking Age, so the details are uncertain.

Think of the two families as two households that learned to share one valley. Each keeps its own job. The Æsir keep oath and order, and the Vanir keep work and plenty. A home that has only one of them is missing something.

**Where this comes from:** The Æsir and Vanir are in the Vǫluspá (Poetic Edda) and Snorri's Prose Edda, both copied late. The idea that they were once two peoples is a scholars' theory, not proven.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which job is missing in your home right now: oath and order, or work and plenty?*

# The Æsir–Vanir war

The Æsir and Vanir once fought a war. The Vǫluspá says the Æsir broke a truce, and the Vanir fought back. Neither side could win for good, so they made peace.

The peace was built on hostages, a person from each side sent to live with the other. Njǫrðr and Freyr went to live among the Æsir. Hænir (Hoenir) and Mímir (Mimir) went to the Vanir. A hostage was a guest, fed and treated well, and that gave both sides a reason to keep their word. A promise is easy to break. A person sitting at the other table is harder to forget.

Njǫrðr and Freyr spent time in Ásgarðr as part of the treaty, but their home is Vanaheimr. The stories do not describe life after the treaty, so think of it this way: each family has its own home and its own job, and they meet at the table. The Vǫluspá and Snorri's Prose Edda tell this as medieval Icelandic story, not as history of a real war.

**Where this comes from:** The war and the hostage exchange are told in the Vǫluspá and Snorri's Prose Edda, both copied late.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one quarrel in your life. Invite the other person to one shared meal this month.*

# The gods at a glance

***Æsir***
**Óðinn**: wisdom, poetry, war, and the dead.
**Frigg**: foresight, marriage, and the household.
**Þórr**: thunder, and guardian of people against giants.
**Sif**: Þórr's wife, with golden hair.
**Týr**: oaths, law, and battle.
**Baldr**: the shining, beloved son of Óðinn and Frigg.
**Heimdallr**: the watchman of the gods.

**Vanir**
**Njǫrðr**: sea, wind, and wealth; father of Freyr and Freyja.
**Freyr**: harvest, fair weather, and peace.
**Freyja**: love, plenty, and half of the slain.

**Others**
**Loki**: the trickster, and father of Hel, Fenrir, and Jǫrmungandr.
**Skaði**: giantess of mountains and winter, wife of Njǫrðr for a time.
**Sól and Máni**: the sun and the moon, sister and brother.

**Where this comes from:** The Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda.

## Óðinn: the one-eyed

Óðinn (Odin) is the chief of the Æsir, the high one, and the god of wisdom, poetry, war, and the dead. He rides the eight-legged horse Sleipnir, shown on picture stones and thin gold medallions called bracteates. Two ravens, Huginn and Muninn, fly out each day and bring him news: thought and memory. Two wolves, Geri and Freki, follow at his heels. The Eddas also call him Alfǫðr (Allfather).

He paid a high price for wisdom. He gave one eye to the well of Mímir (Mimir) for a drink of its water. He hung nine nights on Yggdrasill, wounded by his own spear, to win the runes. The Hávamál gives his long counsel on wits and measure. The Poetic Edda shows him generous and terrible by turns, and he breaks oaths too.

Later books make him a kindly Allfather for modern worship, which is a modern softening. Jackson Crawford, a modern scholar of Old Norse, has argued that the name Alfǫðr may mean 'All Order' rather than 'All-Father'. This reading is debated, and this book does not settle it.

The lesson is in the price. Óðinn wants to know things, and that hunger never comes free. Steady attention counts for more than an altar nobody visits. Give a set hour each week to learning a real craft, a poem, or a history.

**Where this comes from:** Óðinn's eye, hanging, ravens, wolves, and horse are in the Poetic Edda, Snorri's Prose Edda, and on stones. The 'All Order' reading is Jackson Crawford's, and it is debated.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What hard thing will you learn for Óðinn? Name the poem, craft, or history, and the hour.*

## Óðinn: names, mead, and the hall

Óðinn has many names. In the Grímnismál he says he is called Grímnir, Hroptr, Yggr, Gagnráðr, and more. The name Yggdrasill is usually read as "Yggr's horse," and Yggr is Óðinn, because he hung on the tree like a rider on a horse.

His best-known theft is the mead of poetry. In Snorri's Skáldskaparmál, dwarfs killed the wise man Kvasir and brewed his blood into mead, and a giant, Suttungr, ended up hiding it in a mountain under his daughter Gunnlǫð's guard. Óðinn, in disguise, tricked his way in, spent three nights with Gunnlǫð, drank all the mead, and flew out as an eagle. Whoever drinks it becomes a poet. The Hávamál remembers it: "Oblivion's heron... With this bird's pinions I was fettered in Gunnlod's dwelling." (Stanza 13, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

Valhǫll is his hall. The einherjar, warriors chosen by the valkyries, feast and fight there each day until Ragnarǫk, when Óðinn falls to the wolf Fenrir. That is the other half of his story: he gathers warriors, and he knows what he is gathering them for.

**Where this comes from:** The names are in the Grímnismál. The mead of poetry is in Snorri's Skáldskaparmál and the Hávamál. Valhǫll and the einherjar are in the Grímnismál and Snorri's Gylfaginning.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of Óðinn's names or stories do you most want to understand, and why?*

## Frigg: wife and seer

Frigg is the wife of Óðinn and the mother of Baldr. She sits beside the high seat and sees further than she tells. She knows what will come and speaks of it to almost no one. She spins and weaves and keeps the keys and inner doors of the household.

Two stories show her. In the Lokasenna, a poem in the Poetic Edda, she warns Loki that Baldr would have made him pay for his insults, and Loki answers that he is the reason Baldr never rides home. In Snorri's Prose Edda, when Baldr dreams of his death, she makes everything in the world swear not to harm him. She works by foresight and preparation.

Some scholars think Frigg and Freyja may be two names for one goddess. Here Frigg holds marriage and household foresight, and Freyja holds love and growth. In your home, Frigg stands for planning ahead. Look at what winter will ask of your home: lamp oil, savings, rest. Lay one thing ready this week, and cool quarrels before they catch fire.

**Where this comes from:** Frigg's foresight is in the Poetic Edda, and her oath-taking for Baldr is in Snorri's Prose Edda. Scholars debate whether she and Freyja were once one goddess.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Look ahead one season. What does your household see coming, and what one thing will you lay ready this week?*

## Freyja of Fólkvangr

Freyja is the lady of the Vanir, and her name means "lady." She takes half of those slain in battle to her own field, Fólkvangr, and the other half goes to Óðinn. She owns the necklace Brísingamen (Brisingamen), drives a cart drawn by cats, and wears a feather cloak that lets her fly. She knows the craft of love and of fate.

In the Þrymskviða (Thrymskvida), the giant Þrymr steals Þórr's hammer and demands Freyja as his bride. She refuses to be traded, and her anger shakes the halls. Þórr dresses as the bride instead and gets the hammer back. Some scholars think Freyja and Frigg may once have been one goddess, but this book keeps their roles separate.

She stands for plenty and for the right to choose. You may refuse a bad deal outright, and welcome a fair one that brings growth. Say no to any deal that treats you as a price, and keep your worth steady through hard weeks.

**Where this comes from:** Fólkvangr, the necklace, and the feather cloak are in the Poetic Edda. The cat-cart is in Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda. Scholars debate whether Freyja and Frigg were once one goddess.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name a time you refused to be traded. What did you keep, and how?*

## Freyr of harvest and peace

Freyr is the Vanir lord of harvest, fair weather, and peace, and his name means “lord.” He owns the ship Skíðblaðnir (Skidbladnir), which folds up like cloth, and the boar Gullinbursti, with golden bristles. Kings called him an ancestor, and farmers called on him for rain.

In the Skírnismál (Skirnismal), Freyr falls in love with Gerðr (Gerd), a giant maid, and sends his servant Skírnir to win her with gifts and then threats. To get her, Freyr gives away his own sword, and Snorri says he goes to Ragnarǫk without it. Adam of Bremen later describes a fertility god at Uppsala, usually read as Freyr. That account is late and written from a Christian point of view.

His gifts come with a limit. Plenty can turn into greed. Ask yourself what you grew that deserves sharing this season. Pick one loaf, one jar, or one mended thing. Show it to one witness and share it the same day.

**Where this comes from:** The Skírnismál is in the Poetic Edda. The Uppsala account is late and written from a Christian point of view.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What have you grown or made that deserves sharing this season? Share it today.*

## Þórr: driver of the goat cart

Þórr (Thor) is the thunder god of the Æsir and the strongest of them. He drives a cart pulled by two goats, Tanngnjóstr (Tooth-Gnasher) and Tanngrisnir (Tooth-Gritter), and the cart throws sparks as it goes. He has a red beard and the hammer Mjǫllnir (Mjollnir). He guards Miðgarðr, the world of people, against the giants.

In the Þrymskviða poem a giant steals his hammer, and Þórr dresses as a bride to win it back. The hammer is used to bless the bride, and small hammer amulets show that people in the north wore it for protection.

In your own life, this is the work of keeping the boundaries other people rely on. Think of his cart stopping at your gate. The gate latch gets fixed, the inbox gets sorted, and the bedtime routine stays steady. Walk one errand in bad weather. Mending a thing keeps faith with the people who depend on it.

**Where this comes from:** Þórr's hammer, goats, and hallowing are in the Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, and hammer amulets survive.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Who does the sheltering in your life? Name the boundary you depend on and the mending that is yours this week.*

## Skaði: winter's bride

Skaði (Skadi) is a giantess of the mountains and winter, a hunter on skis with a bow. When the gods kill her father, the giant Þjazi (Thiazi), she arms herself and strides into Ásgarðr to take revenge.

The gods offer her a settlement instead. She may choose a husband from among them, but she can see only their feet. She picks the handsomest feet, hoping for Baldr, and finds she has chosen Njǫrðr, the sea god. The gods also make her laugh, when Loki ties a cord between himself and a goat. Óðinn throws Þjazi's eyes into the sky as stars. The marriage is short. She loves the mountains and he loves the sea, so they part, each to their own shore.

Þórr himself boasts of killing Þjazi in the Harbarðsljóð (Harbardsljod). Read her as a story about terms kept. The price is named and paid, and each person lives where they thrive. Plain terms settle a bargain: say what is owed, say what will settle it, and say which place each party keeps afterward.

**Where this comes from:** Skaði's settlement is in Snorri's Prose Edda, and Þórr's boast is in the Harbarðsljóð, both late. The household use was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What bargain of yours needs plain terms? Write what is owed and what settles it.*

## Loki: The Trickster

No devil stands here, whatever later sermons made of him. Snorri's Gylfaginning says Loki was born a giant, the son of Fárbauti and Laufey, and the old texts sometimes name him for his mother, Laufey's son. He lives among the Æsir in Ásgarðr, and in the Lokasenna he reminds Óðinn that the two swore blood-brotherhood. With the giantess Angrboða he fathered Hel, the wolf Fenrir, and the world serpent.

His mischief starts small and turns costly. In Snorri's Prose Edda he cuts off the golden hair of Sif, the wife of Þórr, and Þórr threatens to break every bone in him. Loki goes to the dwarfs for new hair, and the gifts he brings back include Þórr's hammer.

The harm grows. He arranges the death of Baldr, and in the Lokasenna he insults every god at a feast until Þórr threatens him with his hammer and he leaves. At last the gods bind him in a cave with a serpent's venom dripping on him. At Ragnarǫk he breaks free. He is clever, cruel, and useful.

He is cleverness without loyalty, and he cannot be flattered into favors. If trouble with him comes near, bring repair and nothing else. Own the mess and repair it fully, facing the person you hurt directly. The binding and the insults are told in the Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda.

List your tangles. Strike the ones that are only noise. Keep the one that is truly a mess to mend. Clarity is the only answer he respects. One cleanly repaired tangle is worth more than a year of excuses.

**Where this comes from:** Loki's parentage and the story of Sif are in Snorri's Prose Edda. His blood-brotherhood with Óðinn and his binding are in the Lokasenna.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which tangle is your mess to mend, and which is only noise? Name the one mess.*

## Týr (Tyr) of the oath

Týr (Tyr) is the god of oaths and law, and a god of battle and victory. He is best known for losing his right hand. The gods wanted to bind the wolf Fenrir, Loki's son, who had grown too strong. Fenrir would let them tie him only if one of them put a hand in his mouth as a pledge. Týr did, and when the chain held and Fenrir could not break free, the wolf bit the hand off.

The story is told in Snorri's Prose Edda, and the lost hand is named in the Lokasenna. The Sigrdrífumál and the medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon) name his rune for victory. Þórr guards by strength, and Týr guards by oath.

Choose one pledge this week. Make it short enough to keep without footnotes. Say it to one witness, state the cost, and keep it exactly. A kept promise is what makes your word trusted tomorrow.

**Where this comes from:** The binding of Fenrir is in Snorri's Prose Edda, and Týr's rune is in the rune poems and the Sigrdrífumál.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which oath of yours needs a hand behind it? Say it short, to one witness.*

# Days of the week

The Romans invented our seven-day week and named each day for a god or heavenly body: the Sun, Moon, Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus, and Saturn. In the first centuries CE, Germanic peoples, the ancestors of the Norse and English, began using it.

They kept the week but not the Roman gods. For each Roman god they chose the Germanic god who seemed closest.

**Sunday · sunnudagr**
Sól, the sun goddess, who drives the sun across the sky.

**Monday · mánadagr**
Máni, the moon god and Sól's brother, who drives the moon across the sky.

**Tuesday · týsdagr**
Týr, god of oaths and law. He was also a god of battle and victory, so he was matched with Rome's Mars, god of war.

**Wednesday · óðinsdagr**
Óðinn, the high one. He wandered in disguise, ruled poetry and speech, and received the dead, so he was matched with Rome's Mercury, god of speech.

**Thursday · þórsdagr**
Þórr, the thunderer. He ruled thunder and carried the hammer Mjǫllnir, so he was matched with Rome's Jupiter, who wielded the thunderbolt.

**Friday · frjádagr**
Frigg, Óðinn's wife and goddess of marriage, so she was matched with Rome's Venus, goddess of love. Some scholars say it was Freyja instead.

**Saturday · laugardagr**
The Norse named it for bathing, not a god. *Laug* means "bath," so *laugardagr* is "washing day." English kept Rome's Saturn.

**Where this comes from:** The Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda.

## Landvættir (Landvaettir): land-spirits

Landvættir (landvaettir) are land spirits, the unseen guardians of a place. Icelandic stories and law treat them as real neighbors who must be respected. The Landnámabók, a book of Iceland's first settlers, says ships had to remove the carved heads from their prows before landing, so the spirits would not be frightened.

Egils saga shows how seriously people took them. The hero Egill raises a scorn pole, a post topped with a horse's head, and calls on the land spirits to drive out the king who wronged him.

The message is plain for any household: you are a guest on the land. Ask leave, keep your landing clean, and do not foul water or wood. Well-kept ground stays kinder than fouled ground, season after season.

**Where this comes from:** The ship rule is in the Landnámabók and the scorn pole is in Egils saga. The household lessons were written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What ground do you stand on, and who looked after it before you? Leave one place cleaner than you found it.*

## The four guardians of Iceland

In Snorri's Heimskringla, in the saga of Óláfr Tryggvason, a king of Denmark wants to invade Iceland and sends a sorcerer ahead in the shape of a whale. At each coast, the sorcerer sees the land spirits guarding the island. In the east, a huge dragon rises with serpents and toads behind it. In the north, a great bird so large its wings touch the mountains on either side. In the west, a bull wades into the sea, bellowing. In the south, a mountain giant with an iron staff, taller than the hills.

Each of them drives the sorcerer back, and the king gives up the invasion. The four land spirits appear on the Icelandic coat of arms today.

The landvættir are not gods. They guard a place the way a household guards a farm. They are the unseen owners of the land, and the old sources treat them as neighbors to be respected.

**Where this comes from:** The four guardians are in Snorri's Heimskringla, in the saga of Óláfr Tryggvason. The ship rule is in the Landnámabók.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Which of the four guardians would you most want watching your coast? Say why.*

## Nornir: The Norns

The Nornir (Norns) are the women who shape fate. The Vǫluspá names three: Urðr (Urd), Verðandi (Verdandi), and Skuld. Their names are often read as what has been, what is becoming, and what must be.

They live beside the well of Urðr at the foot of Yggdrasill, the world tree. There they carve the lengths of lives and water the tree each day. In Snorri's Prose Edda, other Norns come to every birth to shape that person's life, some kind and some cruel.

Fate and luck are not the same. Fate is the pattern the Norns set, and you cannot choose it. Luck, called hamingja, moves with how you act. Keep your oaths, pay what you owe on time, and give something freely each week.

**Where this comes from:** The Norns and their well are in the Vǫluspá in the Poetic Edda. Snorri's Prose Edda adds the Norns at birth. The idea of luck is in Egils saga.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Where does your luck stand today: rising, steady, or spent? Name one restoring act.*

## Valkyries: choosers

A valkyrie (Old Norse valkyrja, "chooser of the slain") is a warrior woman who serves Óðinn. Valkyries ride to battles and choose who will die, then bring the chosen dead to Valhǫll, Óðinn's hall, where they serve ale to the fallen. The Grímnismál names several: Hrist, Mist, and Skeggjǫld.

In the Sigrdrífumál (Sigrdrifumal), the hero Sigurðr wakes a sleeping valkyrie, Sigrdrífa, whom Vǫlsunga saga calls Brynhildr. She teaches him rune counsel: victory runes for the sword, ale runes for the horn, and birth runes for childbirth.

Her counsel is the part you can use. Before a hard day, ask one elder or steady friend for advice, and say your terms aloud so they can hear. Hard tasks go better with one clear voice beside you.

**Where this comes from:** The valkyrie names are in the Grímnismál in the Poetic Edda, and the counsel is in the Sigrdrífumál. This book offers no rites for calling valkyries.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name your battle this week, and the counsel you will seek before it.*

# Animals

Ravens, wolves, horses, snakes, and eagles

*"Hugin and Munin fly each day over the spacious earth. I fear for Hugin, that he come not back, yet more anxious am I for Munin."*

Grímnismál, stanza 20, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Ravens, wolves, and horses

Animals in the old stories carry meaning. They show what a god or a place is like. Three of them belong to Óðinn.

**Ravens**: Óðinn has two, Huginn and Muninn, whose names mean "thought" and "memory." Each day they fly out over the world and come back to tell him what they saw. In the poem he says he fears most for Muninn. Warriors flew raven banners into battle, and the settler Flóki let ravens loose from his ship to find Iceland.

**Wolves**: Geri and Freki, "greedy" and "ravenous," sit at Óðinn's feet, and he gives them his own food. The great wolf Fenrir is bound by the gods with a ribbon called Gleipnir and bites off the hand of the god Týr. At Ragnarǫk he breaks free and kills Óðinn. Two other wolves, Skǫll and Hati, chase the sun and moon (Sól and Máni) across the sky. Some read their chase as the old explanation for eclipses.

**Horses**: Sleipnir, Óðinn's eight-legged horse, was born to Loki in the shape of a mare. Sleipnir carried the messenger Hermóðr down to Hel. Horses were buried with the dead in Viking graves, so a horse was also a companion for the journey.

**Where this comes from:** Huginn, Muninn, Geri, and Freki are in the Grímnismál. Fenrir, Skǫll, Hati, and Sleipnir are in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda. Flóki is in the Landnámabók, the Icelandic book of settlers. The horse burials are known from archaeology.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these three would you want beside you this week, and what would it do for you?*

## Snakes and eagles

**Snakes**: The Old Norse word ormr means snake, worm, or dragon, so one word covers all three. Jǫrmungandr, the world serpent, lies in the sea around Miðgarðr with his tail in his mouth. Þórr once hooked him while fishing, and at Ragnarǫk the two kill each other. Under Yggdrasill the dragon Níðhǫggr gnaws a root, and the poem says more snakes lie there than any fool imagines. Loki is bound with a snake's venom dripping on his face while his wife Sigyn catches the drops in a bowl.

**Eagles**: An eagle sits at the top of Yggdrasill with a hawk between its eyes. At the north edge of the world sits Hræsvelgr (Hraesvelgr), a giant in eagle shape, and the winds come from his wings. Óðinn took eagle shape to carry the mead of poetry away from the giants. The giant Þjazi (Thjazi) took eagle shape to steal Iðunn (Idunn) and her apples.

Poets also used the raven, wolf, and eagle together. In battle poems they gather to feed on the slain, and scholars call them the beasts of battle. Their coming meant that a fight was near.

**Where this comes from:** The snakes and eagles are in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda. The beasts of battle appear in Old Norse and Old English battle poems.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose the animal that fits your life right now. Write its name and one reason.*

# Tales

Stories from the old books

*"There shall again the wondrous golden tables in the grass be found."*

Vǫluspá, stanza 59, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

# The death of Baldr

Baldr dreams of his own death, and the gods take the dream seriously. His mother, Frigg, goes through the world and takes an oath from fire and water, iron and all metals, stones, earth, trees, sicknesses, beasts, birds, poison, and snakes that none will harm Baldr. The gods then make a game of it. They throw weapons at him, and nothing hurts him.

Loki, jealous, disguises himself as an old woman and visits Frigg. She tells him she asked everything except the mistletoe, which seemed too young to ask. Loki pulls up the mistletoe, returns to the game, and finds Baldr's blind brother Hǫðr (Hodr) standing apart. He puts the mistletoe in Hǫðr's hand and guides his throw. Baldr falls dead.

Hermóðr (Hermod) rides to Hel and asks for Baldr back. Hel says he may return if everything in the world weeps for him. All do, except one giantess, Þǫkk (Thokk), who says she will weep only dry tears. She is usually understood to be Loki in disguise, and Baldr stays in Hel. The gods later bind Loki for his part in it, as the Loki page tells.

**Where this comes from:** Gylfaginning in Snorri's Prose Edda. The Vǫluspá also hints at Baldr's death.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What is one small thing you overlooked that mattered?*

## Egill's grief

Egill Skallagrímsson was a poet and a warrior, and the hero of Egils saga. When his son Bǫðvarr drowned at sea, Egill carried the body to a mound, buried him, and went home. He lay down in his bed-closet and refused to eat or drink, meaning to die. His daughter Þorgerðr (Thorgerd) tricked him by saying she would starve with him, and then by chewing dulse until thirst made them both drink.

She then asked him to compose a poem for his son, and Egill did. The poem, called Sonatorrek ("the loss of sons"), tells of his grief, of his anger at Óðinn, and of how poetry, the gift Óðinn gave, helped him live.

The old pattern is plain: grief is spoken aloud, in words that others can hear. Write four lines for someone you have lost, and read them aloud once.

**Where this comes from:** Egils saga, which includes the poem Sonatorrek.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write four lines for someone you have lost. Read them aloud once.*

# Vǫlva & Seiðr

seeress and fate-work

*"Understand ye yet, or what?"*

Vǫluspá, refrain, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Vǫlva: staff-bearer

A vǫlva (volva) is a seeress, a woman who carries a staff and sees what is hidden. The Vǫluspá is a vǫlva speaking. She is called to the hall of Óðinn and paid to remember. She tells what was: the giants, the dwarfs, and the world tree. Then she tells what comes: winter, breaking, and the last battle. Picture her staff leaning by your chair.

The poem also tells of Heiðr (Heidr), a woman who worked fate craft among households. She was burned three times and born again, never fully welcome and never dismissed.

Read the vǫlva as a witness, not a fortune-teller. The Poetic Edda gives her words, not her method. The one detailed scene of a seeress at work is in Eiríks saga rauða, described later in this chapter, and this book will not invent steps the sources do not give. Guided trance, costume, and ticketed prophecy are modern.

Meet her text honestly at the table with the book open. Read the Vǫluspá slowly across three sittings, ten stanzas at a time. Write down what it warns about in plain words, and date each note so you can see how your questions change.

**Where this comes from:** The seeress speaking is in the Vǫluspá in the Poetic Edda. Trance scripts and modern divination sold as vǫlva-work are modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Read ten stanzas of the Vǫluspá at a sitting, across three sittings. After each, write what it warns about.*

## Seiðr: fate-work with limits

Seiðr (seidr) is a kind of magic tied to fate and spirits, and in the sources it belongs mostly to women. Two mentions in the Poetic Edda carry most of the weight, and both are unkind. In the Vǫluspá, the seeress says Heiðr practiced seiðr wherever she could, a fate worker moving from house to house. In the Lokasenna, Loki mocks Óðinn: he says Óðinn beat the drum like a seeress on Samsey and went about as a witch among men.

So seiðr is shown as powerful, risky, and mocked in the same breath. That is all the Poetic Edda says. One saga, Eiríks saga rauða, describes a seeress's dress, tools, and chants in detail, but no instructions for casting survive. Any staged seiðr with a circle, staff dance, and guided oracle is modern, and so is any lot draw or card read sold as Viking seiðr.

Because no practice survives, this book gives none. The honest work is reading. Read the Vǫluspá stanza about Heiðr and the Lokasenna taunt about Samsey side by side, and write down what each one says and what it leaves out.

**Where this comes from:** Heiðr is in the Vǫluspá and the taunt about Samsey is in the Lokasenna, both in the Poetic Edda. Ritual scripts and divination uses are modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Read the two seiðr mentions side by side. Write what each says and what it leaves out.*

## Seiðr in the sources

The sources that describe seiðr are few. Here they are.

**Vǫluspá**: Heiðr, a seeress who practiced seiðr, is burned three times and born again.
**Lokasenna**: Loki mocks Óðinn for beating a drum and going about as a witch among men.
**Ynglinga saga, chapter 4**: Freyja is a priestess of the sacrifices, and she teaches seiðr to the Æsir.
**Ynglinga saga, chapter 7**: Óðinn can change shape while his body lies as if asleep. Snorri says seiðr could bring harm, and that men who practiced it were shamed, so priestesses taught it.
**Eiríks saga rauða, chapter 4**: a seeress named Þorbjǫrg comes to a Greenland farm in a famine winter. The next page describes her.

What they share: women are the practitioners, a staff is carried, there is a high seat or platform, chanting is involved, and the aim is knowledge of fate. The sources describe seiðr far more than they teach it.

**Where this comes from:** The Vǫluspá and Lokasenna are in the Poetic Edda. Ynglinga saga is in Snorri's Heimskringla. Eiríks saga rauða is an Icelandic saga.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of the five sources would you most like to read in full? Name it and why.*

## A seeress at work: Eiríks saga rauða

In a famine winter in Greenland, a seeress named Þorbjǫrg is invited to a farm to foretell when the hunger will end. The saga describes her in detail.

**Dress**: a blue-black mantle set with stones to the hem, a necklace of glass beads, a black lambskin hood lined with white catskin, calfskin shoes with tin knobs, and catskin gloves white inside.
**Tools**: a staff with a brass knob set with stones, and a belt of touchwood with a large pouch for her charms.
**Seat**: a high seat with a cushion stuffed with hen feathers.
**Food**: porridge of kid's milk, and the hearts of every kind of animal on the farm.
**Chants**: she needs women who know the chants called varðlokur. Only Guðríðr, a young Christian at the farm, knows them, and she sings them reluctantly.
**Result**: the spirits are drawn by the song, and Þorbjǫrg says the famine will end and tells Guðríðr her own future.

The saga was written in the 1200s, by a Christian author, about events around the year 1000. It is the most detailed account of a seeress that survives.

**Where this comes from:** Eiríks saga rauða, chapter 4.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which part of this scene would be hardest to recreate honestly, and why?*

## Hamr: shape and spirit-journey

The old word hamr means shape, or skin. Ynglinga saga, in Snorri's Heimskringla, says Óðinn could change his shape. His body lay as if asleep or dead, while he went as a bird or a beast, a fish or a snake, to far places in a moment. The same saga says his warriors went into battle without mail, as wild as dogs or wolves, and that neither fire nor iron hurt them. These are the berserkers.

Spirit-journeying belongs with seiðr, the work of the seeress. The sources tell us what people believed, but not how it was done. No old text gives steps.

A simple modern version needs no trance. Sit comfortably, close your eyes, and picture an animal you feel close to. Notice how it moves and what it sees. Stay a few minutes, then come back slowly and open your eyes. Write down what you saw. It pairs well with the fylgja page.

**Where this comes from:** Ynglinga saga in Snorri's Heimskringla. The practice is modern, since no source describes how it was done.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which animal came to you? Write what it did and what it saw.*

## Útiseta (Utiseta): sitting out

Útiseta (utiseta) means "sitting out." In Icelandic sagas, a person sits alone at night on a mound or at a crossroads, wrapped in a cloak, to win counsel the household could not give. Verses are sought and dreams are invited. The pattern repeats: alone, overnight, at an edge.

The sagas give the posture, not the steps. No seating plan, staff drill, or summoned voice survives in the sources, and scripted night sittings sold for tickets are modern. Keep it small and safe: a step or garden, with a door unlatched behind you.

Sit once a month for twenty minutes, at dusk or dawn. Carry one question out with you. Do not try to summon anything. Keep your attention open and write down what you noticed.

**Where this comes from:** Mound-sitting is in Icelandic sagas. No ritual survives, and this book offers none.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What question will you carry out to the edge? Sit twenty minutes at dusk or dawn, phone away, and note the light and the sounds.*

# Hamingja

Luck, fylgja, and dreams

*"...but the fair fame never dies of him who has earned it."*
Hávamál, stanza 76, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

# Hamingja: Your Luck

Hamingja is personal luck and family luck, and in Icelandic sagas it follows a person like a second skin. Men speak of luck as plainly as they speak of ships. It grows through generosity and oath-keeping and shrinks through stinginess and broken oaths. Good luck settles on the generous, and bad luck follows the oath breaker.

The old way to bind yourself to something was an oath. In the Sigrdrífumál, the valkyrie Sigrdrífa counsels Sigurðr: "that no oath thou swear, if it be not true. Cruel bonds follow broken faith: accursed is the faith-breaker." (Stanza 23, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.) At Yule, men swore vows over the sacrificial boar.

So this page gives you an oath to keep. Swear one short oath before one witness, for a span you choose, and keep a daily record of whether you kept it. If you slip, say so and mend it the next day. Make the oath small enough to keep.

**Where this comes from:** The idea of luck is in the sagas. The oath warning is in the Sigrdrífumál, and Yule vows are in the sagas. The span is yours to choose.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one oath you can keep, your witness, and the span. Speak it aloud, then mark each day on the oath records that follow.*

*Oath record, days 1–15: did you keep your oath today?*

☐ Day 1 — kept?

☐ Day 2 — kept?

☐ Day 3 — kept?

☐ Day 4 — kept?

☐ Day 5 — kept?

☐ Day 6 — kept?

☐ Day 7 — kept?

☐ Day 8 — kept?

☐ Day 9 — kept?

☐ Day 10 — kept?

☐ Day 11 — kept?

☐ Day 12 — kept?

☐ Day 13 — kept?

☐ Day 14 — kept?

☐ Day 15 — kept?

*Oath record, days 16–30: did you keep your oath today?*

☐ Day 16 — kept?

☐ Day 17 — kept?

☐ Day 18 — kept?

☐ Day 19 — kept?

☐ Day 20 — kept?

☐ Day 21 — kept?

☐ Day 22 — kept?

☐ Day 23 — kept?

☐ Day 24 — kept?

☐ Day 25 — kept?

☐ Day 26 — kept?

☐ Day 27 — kept?

☐ Day 28 — kept?

☐ Day 29 — kept?

☐ Day 30 — kept?

## Fylgja and the parts of a person

The old Norse did not think of a person as only a body. Several words name the parts. The hugr is the mind and will. The hamingja is luck, and it can pass to a relative after death. The fylgja (FIL-gya) is a following spirit tied to a person's fate. It could appear in dreams as a woman or as an animal, and seeing someone's fylgja was taken as a sign of what was coming.

In Víga-Glúms saga, Glúmr dreams of a giant woman striding toward his farm, and the saga reads her as a guardian spirit of his family. The sagas speak of these spirits often, but they never set the words out as one system. The tidy list above is a modern summary that scholars pieced together, so hold it loosely.

A simple practice follows from it. Notice what seems to follow you: an animal that keeps appearing, a figure in your dreams, a pattern in how things go. Write it down on the dream log pages without deciding what it means.

**Where this comes from:** Víga-Glúms saga and other Icelandic sagas. The grouping into parts of a person is a scholarly reconstruction, and the practice was built for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What seems to follow you, an animal, a figure, or a pattern? Write it and when you noticed it.*

## Dreams

In the sagas and the Eddas, dreams are real information. Baldr dreams of his own death in Snorri's Prose Edda and the Baldrs draumar, and the gods take it seriously. In Gísla saga, the hero Gísli is visited by two dream-women, one kind and one threatening, who shape what he does. People who dreamed strongly went to a wise person to have the dream read.

The sources record the dreams and what followed, but they give no method for dream work. A modern, careful practice is to keep a log. Leave a page and a pen by your bed. On waking, before you speak or look at a screen, write the date, one image, and how it felt. Leave the meaning for later, and watch for figures or places that come back.

Read the log after a month. The old stories treat a dream as something to be understood in light of what happens next, so let the pattern teach you, not a book of dream meanings.

**Where this comes from:** Baldr's dreams are in Snorri's Prose Edda and the Baldrs draumar, and the dream-women are in Gísla saga. The dream log is a modern practice.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Tonight, leave a page by your bed. In the morning, write one image before you speak.*

*Dream log: date, one image, how it felt, and anything that has come back before.*

## Naming with water

Old Norse had a phrase, ausa vatni, "to pour water." It names a rite in which a child was sprinkled with water and given a name. In the Rígsþula, a child is sprinkled and named Þræll. In Snorri's Heimskringla, the jarl Sigurðr sprinkles a boy with water and names him Hákon.

Water was used to protect as well. Near the end of the Hávamál, Óðinn lists a charm: water sprinkled on a young warrior so that he will not fall in battle. So water could give a name, and it could shield someone.

To name something with water, set out a bowl of clean water. Say the name aloud. Touch a little water to your hand, then to the brow of the person, the pot of a plant, or the doorway of a new home. Say the name again. It works for a baby, a pet, a project, or a name you choose for yourself.

**Where this comes from:** The Rígsþula, Heimskringla, and the Hávamál charms. The sources do not describe the whole rite, so the practice above is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What new thing in your life needs a name? Say it over water, then write it.*

# Elves & Dwarfs

neighbors and smiths

*"One's own house is best, small though it be; at home is every one his own master."*

Hávamál, stanza 36, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Bright elves and dark elves

Elves (álfar) are shy neighbors in the old poems. You mostly glimpse them at the edge of lamplight. The Grímnismál names Álfheimr as their home. The poems often pair them with the gods in the phrase "Æsir and elves," and the Lokasenna seats them at Ægir's feast. They are beautiful and dangerous outsiders, tied to mounds and fields, and they are neither angels nor demons.

Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda splits them into two groups: light-elves, bright as the sun to look at, and dark-elves, black as pitch, who live down in the earth. That split is late and tidy. The Poetic Edda names elves often but never draws the line cleanly. Some scholars think Snorri may be sorting dwarfs under another name, calling them the smiths of Svartálfaheimr, the dark-elf world. Treat the boundary as blurred.

Think of the elves as unseen neighbors who watch from the edge. You can honor them by stepping softly, keeping paths clear, and leaving one quiet place alone. Practice this in one corner of your week, not in all of it.

**Where this comes from:** Álfheimr is in Grímnismál, and the light and dark split is in Snorri's Prose Edda, which is late and tidy.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Name one spot near your home that feels quietly watched over, and how you will keep it.*

## Freyr: lord of Álfheimr

Álfheimr, the home of the elves, was given to Freyr. The Grímnismál says it was a tooth-gift, a gift marking a child's first tooth. The god was young and of the Vanir. No verse in the Poetic Edda explains what lordship over the elves meant in practice.

Lordship here means something like neighborliness, not rule. The gift binds the elves to him the way two farms share a fence. Read the verse itself before you build any practice on it. This book builds no rite that treats Freyr as king of the elves.

Freyr is linked to fair weather and good harvests on tame ground, and the elves are linked to beauty and danger at the wild edge. The poems never explain how the two meet.

**Where this comes from:** The tooth-gift is in Grímnismál. This book adds no elf-king rites.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Read the Grímnismál stanza that gives Álfheimr to Freyr. Write what it says and what it leaves out.*

# Álfablót (Alfablot): the closed door

Álfablót (alfablot) means "elf sacrifice." It was a rite at summer's end, and almost everything we know comes from one traveler. Sigvatr Þórðarson (Thordarson), a skald, or court poet, of King Óláfr (Olaf), went from farm to farm in Norway seeking a bed and was turned away. In his poem Austrfararvísur (Austrfararvisur), he says each farm was holding an álfablót, which was holy and closed to strangers. The doors were barred and no guest was taken in.

That closed door is nearly all outsiders saw of the rite. Sigvatr's poem is from the early eleventh century, written at about the time. It describes being shut out, not the ritual itself. No prayer, altar plan, or list of offerings survives. The sources support only a few plain points: summer's end, closed doors, and family only. Later farm custom leaves food and drink at mounds and keeps certain hills alone, but that is folk custom and not the same rite.

You can keep the same spirit at home. Pick one evening, close the door to noise, eat quietly, and speak one thank-you aloud. This is one skald's account of farms, not a rule for every farm.

**Where this comes from:** The álfablót is in Sigvatr's Austrfararvísur, a poem from the time. No account of the rite itself survives.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*When will you bar your door early for one quiet meal with thanks? Name the date, the meal, and the people.*

## Elves in the ground

Elves are still present in place names long after the Poetic Edda falls quiet. Farms and fields across Norway and Sweden carry elf-names, and Álfheimr was even the name of a region. Some stones and mounds were left alone by plows, while the plows cut straight through everything else. Icelandic sagas describe mounds honored with toasts poured at the door-stone and paths swept clean. The dead inside were called mound-dwellers, and they were not always clearly separate from elves.

This is about the land, not about formal teachings. Place names last longer than the books that record them. Elf-names are shown on stones and in farm-names recorded in Landnámabók, and folk custom still shows farmers leaving certain mounds and hills alone. Iceland's huldufolk, the hidden people, kept the same courtesy the longest.

Your street may keep a version of this too, perhaps the corner no one builds on, or the tree no one cuts. You can do the same on your block: leave one tree, one patch of ground, or one corner alone. Leave it be, and do not take what is not yours.

**Where this comes from:** Elf place-names and mound-honor are in old records and folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Walk your block and look for places people leave alone. Mark two spots.*

## Honoring without summoning

Elves were not worshipped the way the gods were. No temple to elves has been found, and no priest is named for them. The one sign of honor on record is the closed door at summer's end. Offerings at mounds and hills in Icelandic sagas were small. They were poured or laid down and left alone, with no attempt to call anything up. The Lokasenna seats the elves among the gods at Ægir's feast. They are guests and witnesses, not servants.

The old practice was courtesy without command. People cleaned up edges and lowered noise near nesting ground. They asked leave before taking, and they gave thanks after. Nothing was summoned, bound, or bought. The mound toasts are a pattern in Icelandic sagas, and the quiet-edge practice is rebuilt from that pattern. It is good manners, not control.

Keep one edge this way: choose one patch of ground or one shared space. Ask before you take from it, give thanks after, and leave it quieter than you found it. That is all this practice asks.

**Where this comes from:** Mound offerings are in Icelandic sagas. This book offers no summoning rites.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which edge will you keep this month, using only good manners?*

## Born from earth and sea

Dwarfs (dvergar) are the smiths and craftsmen of the old stories, and they live in the earth and rock. The Vǫluspá gives them the longest list of names in the Poetic Edda but almost no description. After the gods shape the world, the dwarfs come to life in the earth, like maggots that grow in flesh, according to Snorri's Prose Edda. In the Vǫluspá they are shaped from Ymir's bones and from the blood of the sea-giant Brimir, and the gods give them mind and shape.

The long list holds names like Northri and Southri, Austri and Vestri, Gandalf and Thorin. Many of the names point to stone, staff, or advice. Think of dwarfs first as powers of the earth, and only second as people. They avoid daylight and work metal. Later books make them short, comic miners with axes, and that picture is modern. The Poetic Edda shows skill, advice, and cost, and no comedy.

The dwarf list was made to be said aloud. Start with four names: Northri, Southri, Austri, and Vestri. In Snorri's Prose Edda they hold up the four corners of the sky. Say them once each day for a week.

**Where this comes from:** The dwarf origins and name lists are in the Vǫluspá and Snorri's Prose Edda, which is late.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which three dwarf-names will you learn first? Say them aloud.*

## Treasures from the forge

The gods could not have their finest tools without dwarfs to make them, and every gift had a cost. In Snorri Sturluson's Skáldskaparmál (Skaldskaparmal), Loki cut the hair of Sif, Þórr's wife, for sport, and had to pay for it. He got new hair of gold from the dwarfs called the sons of Ívaldi (Ivaldi), who also made Skíðblaðnir, a ship that folds up, and Gungnir, a spear that never misses. Then Loki bet his head against the dwarfs Brokkr and Sindri that they could not do better. They made Draupnir, a gold ring that drips more gold, Gullinbursti, a golden boar, and Mjǫllnir, a hammer with a short handle.

Loki's head was on the line, and only his wordplay saved him. The hammer's handle is short because Loki, as a fly, stung the smith's brow while he worked. The cost matters more than the shine. Every treasure costs something, good work costs effort, and careless tricks with other people's goods bring trouble.

Sif's gold hair shows the pattern: a careless wrong is repaired by fine work, and the repair is paid for. Use that lesson in your own life. Fine work deserves to be honored, not just owned.

**Where this comes from:** The Ívaldi and Brokkr treasures are in Skáldskaparmál, a late prose work.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which fine-made thing of yours needs mending? Name it, and its maker.*

## Vǫlundr (Volund) the smith

Vǫlundr (Volund) is the greatest of the elven-smiths, a master of metal who ends up crippled and captive. The Vǫlundarkviða (Volundarkvida) tells his story. King Níðuðr (Nidud) hamstrung him, cutting the tendons in his legs so he could not walk well, and made him forge on the king's island. Vǫlundr killed the king's sons in revenge for what was done to him and made cups from their skulls. Then he flew away on wings of his own making, and the king was left grieving.

Vǫlundr is a warning, not a patron. The poem does not make him gentle. The tale is in the Poetic Edda, and it reads as stark and early. Honoring Vǫlundr with a hammer and forge is a modern craft practice, honest only when called so. The lesson is plain: skilled people who serve a household should not be held against their will.

Pay the people who make things for you fairly, and thank them by name. Work freely given and fairly paid is the everyday opposite of Vǫlundr's chains.

**Where this comes from:** Vǫlundr's story is in the Vǫlundarkviða in the Poetic Edda. Smith-patron rites are modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Whose skilled work do you rely on without thanks? Name them and one way you will thank them.*

## Alvíss (Alvis): all-wise till dawn

Alvíss (Alvis) is a dwarf who stayed talking until dawn, and that was his undoing. In the Alvíssmál (Alvissmal), Alvíss comes to claim Þórr's daughter as his bride, saying she was promised to him. Þórr does not refuse him outright. He asks the dwarf riddles about what each world calls earth, sky, and ale, and he keeps him talking until sunrise.

The poem ends with the sun in the hall. In a later telling, daylight turns dwarfs to stone, and that is how Alvíss ends. Þórr wins with talk and delay, and no magic. The lesson still applies. Answer a hard bargain with questions, not force. Sleep on a deal, and it may look different in daylight.

You can use the same tactic on a hard bargain: wait for daylight, and make the other side answer your questions in writing.

**Where this comes from:** The Alvíssmál is a poem in the Poetic Edda. Daylight turning dwarfs to stone is a later telling.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What pressure wants you to sign now? Write its three questions, and sleep before signing.*

# Norse Wheel of the Year

Winter Nights to Midsummer

*"She sees arise, a second time, earth from ocean, beauteously green."*

Vǫluspá, stanza 57, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## An honest wheel

The old northern year was measured by work. In spring, lambs were born and seed went into the ground. In autumn, hay was stacked, cattle came in from the pasture, meat was salted for winter, and boats were hauled up onto land. Five seasonal turnings survive by name: Winter Nights, Yule, Dísablót (Disablot), Sigrblót (Sigrblot), and Midsummer. They come to us through Icelandic sagas, Snorri Sturluson's Heimskringla, Christian calendars, and folk memory. The sources are thin in places, and customs varied from district to district.

The old north counted two seasons, summer and winter. Summer began in late April, with spring as its start and autumn as its end. Winter began in late October.

This book stays close to northern sources. You may know the eight-spoke wheel, which spaces the solstices and equinoxes evenly. It was put together in the last century from several cultures, so it is a modern tool and not an old northern one. This book uses the five northern turnings instead, and it marks thin evidence as thin. Midsummer is a later folk custom. The book watches the moon for pleasure and does not force a pattern onto it.

A year like this is learned by doing. One marked date teaches more than any diagram, and one small task you finish is worth more than a shelf of plans. Start with one date. Write it down in ink, and the rest of the year will have a fixed point to measure by.

**Where this comes from:** The five turnings are named in Icelandic sagas, Snorri's Heimskringla, and folk custom, but the sources are thin. The eight-spoke wheel is a modern invention.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Find which of the five turnings comes next, and mark its date in ink. Choose one small task to finish before the week ends.*

## How each turning works here

Most turnings follow the same pattern. First comes the story, as the Poetic Edda and Icelandic sagas tell it. Next comes the old practice, as far as it can be recovered. Then comes a practice built on it, sized for a flat and one evening, then something for the table, and last a prompt for your own notes. Dísablót has only one page, because the sources say almost nothing about it.

Old winters ran on food, fire, and company. In these pages you will meet the Yule peace, toasts to the ancestors, cleaned thresholds, and hill walks. Some of it is old, some is custom that lasted into recent times, and some was written for this book. Each page says which.

Your household already knows how to feast. Birthday bread comes to the table on its own plate. One soup fixes everything. One pudding is always asked for. This chapter adds five old names to the dishes you already love. Say an old name over a dish you already cook, and the meal becomes a marker of the season.

**Where this comes from:** How this chapter works. Its method is modern, built on old sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *List the dishes that already mean joy at your table. You will use them when you reach the table pages.*

## Blot: simply

A blót (blot) was an old offering feast. In Hákonar saga góða, part of Snorri Sturluson's Heimskringla, people gather and a gift is given. Blood is caught and sprinkled with twigs on the walls and on the people. Toasts are drunk in order: to the gods, to the ancestors, and to victory. Then everyone feasts on the gift itself. The full cup is the toast to the gods, and the minni cup is the toast to memory, passed hand to hand.

The old hall shrinks to a table here, and this book does not pretend to rebuild it. The modern blot has three acts. Set out a gift of water, milk, bread, song, or work. Speak aloud the names of who receives it. Eat a share or carry it out, with thanks. The Hávamál warns about the size of the gift: "'Tis better not to pray than too much offer; a gift ever looks to a return." (Stanza 147, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.) So give no more than you can spare, and ask for nothing back.

The whole practice fits inside half an hour. Nothing is buried, nothing is poured where it fouls water, and no coins are left in springs. Carry out every trace before you sleep. Repeat it at the next turn of the month. Passing the cup from hand to hand keeps memory alive.

**Where this comes from:** The toasts and blood-sprinkling are in Hákonar saga góða, and the warning about the gift is in the Hávamál. The household blot was rebuilt for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What gift will you set out this month, and who receives it by name?*

*Gift log: what did you give, and to whom? The Hávamál says a gift looks for a return, so give without asking.*

- ☐ Gift (water, milk, bread, song, or work) and date
- ☐ To whom — name the figure
- ☐ Who shared it with you
- ☐ Leave-no-trace check (carried out?)
- ☐ Week two gift
- ☐ Week three gift
- ☐ Week four gift

## A small seasonal altar

The old texts mention altars and shrines, but they say little about what stood in a home. In the Hyndluljóð (Hyndluljod), Óttarr builds a hǫrgr (horg), a heap of stones, for Freyja. The sources do not describe a household altar, so what follows is a modern habit built on the old idea of a set-aside place for gifts.

Choose a shelf, windowsill, or the end of a table. Set a small bowl or cup for the gift, a light, something from the season, and a note with the names you will say at the turning. Winter Nights could carry bread and a family name. Yule could carry greens and a written vow. Midsummer could carry flowers and a bit of fruit.

Change the season piece at each turning. After a blót, clear the gift away the same day, as the blót page says. Keep the place clean and plain. It is a table you pay attention at, nothing more.

**Where this comes from:** The hǫrgr is in the Hyndluljóð in the Poetic Edda. The household altar is a modern practice.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Where will your altar sit? Name the spot and the first item you will place there.*

## Hallowing: the hammer sign and fire

To hallow something is to set it apart as sacred. The old texts show two ways. In Hákonar saga góða, King Hákon is a Christian who is pressed to drink at a heathen feast. He makes the sign of the cross over the cup, and the angry farmers are told that the king is only doing what everyone does: blessing the cup in Þórr's name with the sign of the hammer.

The other way was fire. In the Landnámabók, early settlers in Iceland claimed land by carrying fire around it, and in Eyrbyggja saga Þórólfr Mostrarskegg carries fire around the land he claims. The fire marked a line between what was his and what was not.

Both can be done at home. To hallow a cup before a toast, hold your hand over it and draw the shape of a hammer in the air, say the name of who you are honoring, and then drink. To hallow a room or a yard, carry a lit candle along its edges, saying aloud that this place is yours and will be kept well. Put the flame out when you are done.

**Where this comes from:** The hammer sign is in Hákonar saga góða in Snorri's Heimskringla. The fire claim is in the Landnámabók and Eyrbyggja saga. The two practices above are modern, built on those two reports.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What will you hallow first: a cup, a doorway, a room? Name it and the words you will say.*

## The Rök stone and the calendar sticks

A tall grey stone stands in Östergötland, in Sweden. It is covered edge to edge with runes. It is the Rök stone, raised in the 800s. It holds the longest runic text from the Viking Age known to us. Its lines use alliteration, the repeated starting sounds of poetry, and tell of heroes, battles, a wolf, and robbery. The stone was carved with great care. Weather has worn it, but its writing can still be read.

The stone is a memorial and nothing more. Scholars still disagree about many of its lines. Nothing on it lists a festival or a calendar date, so it cannot prove any of the turnings here. Later calendar sticks, carved wooden sticks that counted feasts and moons, are a separate source. Their marks differ from valley to valley. The turnings do not depend on the stone.

The old calendar sticks share one habit worth borrowing. They keep count over time. The moon still waxes and wanes over your street. Looking at the sky twice a month builds steady attention. Short notes kept over time are more useful than arguments about the past. Step outside, look up, and write down what you see.

**Where this comes from:** The Rök stone dates to the 800s, and calendar sticks come later. No one knows whether the stone had any festival use.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Step outside tonight and find the moon. Is it waxing or waning? Keep notes for two months.*

*Moon tracker, two months: watch the sky, don't rebuild old rites. Note new and full moon dates.*

- ☐ Month one, new moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month one, full moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month one — what changed around you?
- ☐ Month two, new moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month two, full moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month two — what changed around you?
- ☐ Which turning falls inside these two moons?
- ☐ One line: what did the moon teach?

## Vetrnætr (Vetrnaetr): kin and burial mounds

Winter Nights (Vetrnætr) is the feast that opens winter, and it ran over three nights in late October. The harvest is in, the herds are housed, and the autumn slaughter is done. Icelandic sagas and calendars name it. Families gathered to honor their kin and the land spirits, and to thank the dísir (disir), female guardian spirits linked to households. A blót, a gift to gods and spirits often shared as a meal, was held, and toasts, drinks raised to a name or a wish, were drunk. Some sagas show toasts to Njǫrðr and Freyr for peace and plenty. Burial mounds were visited as the leaves turned.

The feast had two jobs at once. The living kin were fed first. Then the dead of the burial mounds and the dísir were thanked. The threshold was swept clean, and the main work of the day was to bring everyone, living and dead, under one roof.

The old feast turned toward the dead. If there is a grave or an old mound near you, visit it as the leaves turn, and say one name aloud.

**Where this comes from:** The Winter Nights blot is in Icelandic sagas and calendars, but thinly. The details come from later folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Visit a grave, a mound, or a place where someone is remembered. Say one name aloud.*

## Vetrnætr: table and kin

The feast uses food stored for winter. Salt pork comes with mashed root vegetables. Morning porridge comes with butter. Dark bread comes with thick slices of cheese. Ale or a fruit cordial is raised in toasts. Old feasts used the food from the slaughter season. Eat in the warmest room you have. Light a few candles against the October dark.

When the meal ends, the toasts begin. A toast is a drink raised to a name or a wish. Keep all the toasts to ten minutes. Raise three toasts aloud in plain words. Toast the kin present, then thank the dísir and landvættir (land spirits). Toast a winter kept well. Finish each cup. The food is later folk custom. The spoken toasts keep an old custom alive today.

Three short sentences, kept for a season, teach more about family than a long list of resolutions. Keep each toast plain enough for a child to understand. Speak it standing, with your feet on the floor. Then keep saying it through the winter. Plain thanks spoken aloud link the living and the dead in your family's memory.

**Where this comes from:** Slaughter-season foods and toasts come from later folk custom, with hints in the sagas.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write three toasts, plain enough for a child, and speak them standing: to your kin, to the dísir and landvættir, and to a winter kept well.*

# Jól (Yule): midwinter peace

Jól (Yule) is the old northern midwinter feast, most likely held just after the winter solstice. The word is plural because the celebration lasted about three nights, with feasting and drinking. Horse was one of the meats served. Doors were often barred early. Toasts went to gods and ancestors, and a peace lay over households, so that even enemies could eat without feud.

Jól was also the time for oaths. The sagas tell of oaths sworn then, and an oath sworn at Jól was iron-bound and held extra sacred. Breaking it could be punished by death. People might swear over a boar, the way one swears on a Bible, or over a ring. Some poems and sagas tell of vows made at Jól being kept later in battle.

Folk custom keeps the same shape in plainer clothes. Straw, a candle, and a cleaned house mark the season. The home grows quiet as the old names are spoken. You do not need a crowd or costumes.

Jól is the time for vows. Before you make a new one, look back at the vows you made last winter and say honestly which you kept. Then speak the names of the dead over supper, one sentence each.

**Where this comes from:** Yule feasting and oaths are thinly recorded in the Poetic Edda and Icelandic sagas. The details come from later folk custom. The timing, the plural name, the horse meat, and the oath details are Dr. Jackson Crawford's.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sit with last year's vows and note which you kept. Then speak the names of your dead over supper, one sentence each.*

# Yule: the vow and the supper

The old practice centered on feast and vow. People gathered and a peace was announced, and feuds paused under it. Oaths were sworn over a boar, a vow made in front of witnesses and kept later, even in battle. The hall was crowded with meat stored for winter, and doors were barred early against the cold.

Keep the shape at your own table. Make a plain supper from stored food: a stew, bread, apples and nuts. Before the meal, each person speaks one vow aloud for the year, with the others as witnesses. Set one extra plate for the dead, a custom kept in Scandinavian homes into recent times, and speak each ancestor's name with thanks.

Write the vows down so they can be checked at the next Yule. The Ancestors pages give a fuller way to remember the dead. The next morning, leave a share out for the birds.

**Where this comes from:** Feast and vow-drinking are thinly recorded in the sagas. The extra plate comes from later Scandinavian folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Hold this supper this week: one simple dish, an extra plate, each ancestor's name, and one vow for the year before a witness.*

# Dísablót: the ladies' feast

Dísablót took place during Winter Nights (Vetrnætr), the three nights in late October that open winter. The name means a sacrifice to the dísir (disir), female guardian spirits linked to kin, households, and fate. The offering was made in the Dísarsalr (Disarsalr), the hall of the dísir. It was a private rite, held by a family for its own dísir, who may be a form of that family's ancestors. Some sources link Freyja to them, since she is also called Vanadís, lady of the Vanir. The Icelandic sagas name the feast but never describe it in detail. A later Swedish market, Disting, is sometimes linked to this feast, and the Idisi in the Merseburg charms were women called on to help warriors.

The sources are thin, and this page says so. No prayer, altar plan, or menu survives, and the Disting fair is a late link, not proof. This book builds one honest practice, clearly modern: a Winter Nights supper that honors the women whose work shaped your household, living and dead, by name and aloud. Naming them gives them a place at the table.

Once a year is enough. Cook one dish from stored food, and name each woman in one true sentence while you eat. The fuller supper plan is on the Ancestors pages. Naming women who are often forgotten keeps their memory alive in your family.

**Where this comes from:** The dísir and the dísablót are named in the Icelandic sagas, but thinly. Disting is a later market. The timing, the Dísarsalr, and the family rite are Dr. Jackson Crawford's. The supper was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Hold your supper on one of the three Winter Nights in late October. Cook one dish from stored food and name each woman with one true sentence.*

## Sigrblót: turn to summer

Sigrblót (Sigrblot) means "victory sacrifice," an offering made at the start of summer, in late April, for success. The kings' sagas, such as Ynglinga saga in Snorri's Heimskringla, name it as an offering for the summer's voyages. It was made to ask for fair winds and success in war and at sea, and toasts were drunk before ships set out. Picture tar on rope at the shore, gulls over the crews, and a sail filling in an April wind.

Crews mended their gear before they sailed. Your household can keep the same shape: name the work you are about to begin, and say aloud what would make it a success. The name Sigrblót is recorded only thinly, and the household version is modern.

The old rite was a toast and a vow for the season's work. Name one voyage you will launch this summer, such as a project, a trip, or a change, and say it aloud before a witness.

**Where this comes from:** Sigrblót is named in the kings' sagas, such as Ynglinga saga, but thinly. The household version was rebuilt for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the voyage you will launch this summer and what would make it a success. Say it aloud to one witness.*

## Sigrblót: table and pledge

The table holds the first fresh foods of the year, which feel like a sharp break from winter. Green salads come with fresh cheese. Oatcakes come with honey. Home-brewed ale is poured where custom allows. Grill something outdoors if you have the space. People in flats can skip the grill and share warm bread. Set the meal near safe light, such as lamps or a few candles well away from curtains. The meal may run later than usual.

A pledge is a promise made out loud. You can make it alone or with dozens of people. Name one voyage you will launch this summer, such as a project, a trip, or a change. Say its course, its crew, and the harbor you are heading for. Drink the cup in front of witnesses, however few. Shared greens and shared meals are later folk custom. Speak it plainly and keep your word.

This practice works best when you plan first. Saying a plan aloud to others makes it harder to forget. Prepare for your voyage, then keep your word, even when it is hard. Take one step you have planned, and your summer begins.

**Where this comes from:** Spring greens and shared eating come from later folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Plan the meal, and at it stand and drink to your voyage: its course, its crew, and where it should end.*

## Midsummer: light that does not leave

Midsummer is a summer gathering around a bonfire and fresh green branches, and people in the north still remember it. It comes with flower crowns and hill fires. Many northern farms kept some part of it. Folk collectors such as Tillhagen recorded Midsummer greens and the custom of picking herbs at noon, and fires lit against a night that barely gets dark. Crowns wilted by midnight.

Joy taken with care is the mark of this day. People climb hills, enjoy the greenery only where that is allowed, and leave no trace. Food from many hands is shared. Name the grower, the carrier, and the cook. A flower means more when you name the people who brought it. Named thanks last longer than the feast.

Share one joy with one witness before the week ends. That is Midsummer kept small. A swim, a song, or a nap in full daylight will do. Choose one joy and tell someone about it. When you name the people who helped you find that joy, the light of the season stays with you longer.

**Where this comes from:** Midsummer greens and fires come from later folk custom. No old poem is claimed for them.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one joy you will mark at the height of summer, and share it with one witness before the week ends.*

## Midsummer: old practice, modern rite

As folk collectors recorded it, the old practice meant a fire and green plants. People walked uphill in crowds. Crowns were twisted at noon. Herbs were picked and hung up to dry. The summer light was praised where everyone could see it. Your modern practice keeps both at a size your week can hold. The hill can be a park slope, or a flight of stairs you count honestly. Your legs will feel the climb.

Taste one summer food on purpose. It may be grown at home, bought, or given by a neighbor with plenty. Then give thanks out loud. Speak one promise of care to someone who can hear it. Keep the promise short and specific. Say it slowly, then say it again so it sticks. Name the food and the person who shared it, so your thanks has a clear face.

In the old custom, greens and thanks belonged together. Climb a hill, speak a promise, and keep both in mind. Pick one clear step to take after the walk, and write it down.

**Where this comes from:** Hill fires and crowns come from later folk custom. The home version was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Plan a walk that fits inside an hour: the hill or stairs, how you mark the climb, and when it ends.*

## NORSE WHEEL OF THE YEAR

*Your own wheel: plan the five turnings, and note what you will keep.*

- ☐ Winter Nights (late October): whose names will I say? What will I cook?
- ☐ Yule (midwinter): what vow will I make, and who will witness it?
- ☐ Dísablót (Winter Nights): who will I thank, and how?
- ☐ Sigrblót (start of summer, late April): what pledge will I make for the warm half of the year?
- ☐ Midsummer: where will I light a fire or gather greens?
- ☐ Which turning feels most like yours?
- ☐ What will you repeat every year?
- ☐ One line: what did the wheel teach you?

# Plants & Trees

Healing plants, food, and trees

*"...earth is good against drink, fire for distempers, ... a corn-ear for sorcery."*

Hávamál, stanza 139, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Safety box — read first

Some plants in this chapter can harm you, so read this page first. Yew is toxic in every part. Many herbs in the old medical books are strong, and some are dangerous in pregnancy or alongside modern medicines. Never swallow or apply anything from these pages just because an old book says so.

The rule for this chapter is simple. The old remedies here are history. Look at plants, learn their names, and keep notes. Do not gather wild plants without an expert beside you, and never drink wild water. Leave no trace outdoors, and carry out everything you carry in.

Check any herb against your medicines with a clinician first. If you are or may be pregnant, check with a clinician before using any herb. Careful watching and a written rule help you learn without harm.

**Where this comes from:** Toxicity and caution come from classical and modern medical knowledge.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write your own safety line. Name what you will never swallow and who your expert will be.*

## Healing plants in the sagas and poems

No list of Viking Age herbs survives. What we have are scattered mentions. In Ólafs saga helga, part of Snorri's Heimskringla, a wounded man named Þormóðr (Thormod) is offered a hot broth of leeks, onions, and other herbs by a healer woman, who wants to smell the wound to learn whether it has pierced the belly. He refuses it.

The Sigrdrífumál says a cup must be blessed and guarded against danger, and that garlic must be cast into the liquor: "then I know thou wilt never have mead with treachery mingled." (Stanza 8, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.) The Old Norse word is laukr, which means leek, onion, or garlic. The same poem teaches healers to cut runes on the bark and leaves of trees (stanza 11).

The herb lists that do survive are in Icelandic medical books from the 1200s to the 1400s. The next pages cover what they say. They were written by Christian scribes, so they are medieval, not Viking Age.

**Where this comes from:** Ólafs saga helga in Snorri's Heimskringla, and the Sigrdrífumál in the Poetic Edda in Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation. The medical books are described in Luthien Cangemi's The Art of Healing in Medieval Iceland (UCL, 2024).

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Look up laukr. Where could you find it in your own kitchen, and what did the old sources use it for?*

## Yarrow: greni

Yarrow is easy to recognize once you learn its signs. Its leaves are feathery, like green lace. Its flat white flower heads stand along hedges all summer. Old books call it soldier's woundwort. In Old Icelandic medical books it is greni, also written millefolium, "thousand leaves."

A fifteenth-century Icelandic medical manuscript, AM 434 a 12mo, gives yarrow three uses: chew the root while fasting for toothache; drink the juice with wine to clear the urine; and crush it and lay it on a wound, which it says heals every wound remarkably well. The same manuscript also uses yarrow in a ritual to find a thief, mixing the herb with a carved sign, a spoken charm, and a Christian closing formula. These are quoted here as history, not as instructions.

This book asks you only to look. Yarrow can cause skin irritation in some people. Never use it in place of prescribed medicine, and never for deep or doubtful wounds. Count ten clumps on a walk and sketch one leaf.

**Where this comes from:** Yarrow as greni is in AM 434 a 12mo, as described in Luthien Cangemi's thesis. The manuscript was edited by Kristian Kålund and translated by Ben Waggoner.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *On a walk, count the yarrow clumps you pass and sketch one leaf. Do not gather anything.*

## More herbs in the leechbooks

The same manuscript names other herbs, most of them known across medieval Europe. Betony (betonica), drunk with water at dawn, brightens the eyes, and ground in old wine and oil it drives out poison. Centaury juice mixed with honey takes the film from the eyes. Rue, grown at home, is used with honey or sour wine for running or dim eyes, and ground in oil for headache.

Pennyroyal is boiled in oil and rubbed on the forehead and temples for headache, or boiled in wine or ale for a swollen belly. Horehound is said to cleanse the lungs when drunk often. Many of these match the Old English Herbarium and the Lacnunga from the tenth century, which shows that Icelandic scribes were copying a shared European tradition and giving some plants Icelandic names.

So these are medieval Icelandic remedies, not Viking Age ones, and some of the plants were grown in gardens, not found wild. They are recorded here as history. This book does not recommend any of them. If you are unwell, see a clinician.

**Where this comes from:** AM 434 a 12mo and Dublin, Royal Irish Academy MS 23 D 43, as described in Luthien Cangemi's thesis. Compare the Old English Herbarium and the Lacnunga.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these herbs have you seen growing near you? Note where. Do not pick it.*

## Laukr: the leek

Laukr is the Old Norse word for leek, and it covers onion and garlic too. It is one of the oldest plant words in northern writing. A runic inscription on a bone object from Fløksand in Norway, from about the fourth century, is often read "linen, leek, wealth," and the word laukaz appears again on gold bracteates, often beside alu, a word thought to mean ale or protection. Nobody is sure what these short inscriptions meant, but the leek was clearly a charged word.

The leek shows up again in the sagas and poems. In the Sigrdrífumál, a cup is guarded by casting garlic into the liquor. In Ólafs saga helga, a healer's broth of leeks, onions, and herbs is used to find out whether a wound has pierced the belly. That is what the old sources show: a plant used for protection, for charm words, and for testing wounds.

This book makes no claim beyond that. Find leek, onion, and garlic in your own kitchen and learn the three names.

**Where this comes from:** The Fløksand inscription and the bracteates are runic finds, with the reading laukaz as leek widely accepted. The Sigrdrífumál is in the Poetic Edda, and Ólafs saga helga is in Snorri's Heimskringla.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find leek, onion, and garlic in your kitchen. Write each name and what it is used for.*

## Sǫl: dulse

Sǫl is dulse, a red seaweed that grows on rocks along the Icelandic shore. The sagas know it as food. In Egils saga, after Egill's son has died and Egill refuses to eat, his daughter Þorgerðr (Thorgerd) gets him to chew dulse, and he remarks that dulse makes a person thirstier. The thirst makes him drink, and that is the first step back toward living.

Dulse is a food in the sources, not a medicine. It is one of the plants with the earliest written record as food in Iceland, in the early 12th century, though people probably ate it from the time of the Settlement.

Do not gather seaweed or any wild food without local knowledge, and never from polluted shores. Read the dulse scene in Egils saga slowly, and notice how little it asks of the reader: a daughter, a plant, and a hard moment.

**Where this comes from:** Egils saga. The early written records of dulse as food are noted by the Slow Food Ark of Taste.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Read the dulse scene in Egils saga. Write what the daughter's trick shows about dulse.*

## Barley and ale

Barley was the main grain of the Viking Age north. It grew in short summers and fed households as porridge, bread, and ale. Ale (ǫl) stands at the center of the old stories. At the blót, the full cup was drunk to the gods and the minni cup to the dead. In the Sigrdrífumál, the valkyrie brings Sigurðr a horn of mead and teaches him ale-runes. In the Hávamál, ale is also a warning: "A worse provision on the way he cannot carry than too much beer-bibbing." (Stanza 11, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

To make ale, barley is malted: soaked until it sprouts, then dried. This book does not teach brewing. Learn what malt is, and where the toast begins.

**Where this comes from:** Barley as the main grain comes from the archaeology of Viking Age farms. The ale passages are in the Hávamál, the Sigrdrífumál, and Hákonar saga góða.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Look at a bag of barley or malt. Write what it looks like and one place ale appears in the old sources.*

## Pine: tar and light

Pine was one of the most useful trees in the north. Its wood gave ship timbers and masts, and its resin was boiled into tar for sealing boats and rope. Resin-rich pine wood, called torchwood, was split for light. Knotty roots were split for kindling, and that kindling carried light through the Yule dark.

Find a pine and notice what the old north noticed: the resin, the scent, and the light that falls in shafts between the trunks. Nothing in the sources asks for a ritual with pine. It was a working tree.

**Where this comes from:** Pine tar for ships and torchwood for light are known from archaeology and folk life.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find your nearest pine. Note where it grows and whether you can see resin.*

## Plantain: læknnesgras

Plantain grows flat where feet go. Its ribbed leaves press close to the path. Its flower spikes rise like thin green candles. The Icelandic medical manuscripts translate its Latin name into plain Icelandic, læknnesgras, roughly "healing herb."

AM 434 a 12mo says to grind the root in cold water and give it to a man or a cow for fever, and promises quick recovery. English folk names for it, way-bread and wound leaf, show how widely it was known. In hard years its seeds were saved and added to porridge. It stays low, gets stepped on, and still grows back.

This book does not ask you to use plantain on your body or in food. The old uses are history, not instructions. Never use it in place of prescribed care, and never on deep or dirty wounds.

**Where this comes from:** Plantain as læknnesgras is in AM 434 a 12mo, as described in Luthien Cangemi's thesis. The English names and the seed use come from folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find a plantain on a path and study its leaves and spikes for ten minutes. Sketch it. Do not pick it.*

## Trees in the rune poems

The Anglo-Saxon rune poem gives each tree rune a short verse, and four of them are trees you will meet in this chapter. The oak (ac) is fodder for the flesh, usually read as pigs fed on acorns, and it carries ships over the sea. The ash (æsc) is very tall and dear to people, stout in its trunk, and makes a spear shaft that holds firm when many attack it. The yew (eoh) is rough on the outside, hard and fast in the earth, a guardian of flame and a joy upon an estate. The birch (beorc) bears no fruit, yet sends up twigs without seed, with a lofty crown that reaches the sky.

These are English verses, not Norse, but the Norwegian and Icelandic rune poems speak the same way: one plain thing, one short saying. Together they show how people thought about a tree: what it gave, what it made, and how it stood.

**Where this comes from:** The Anglo-Saxon rune poem, which survives only in a copy printed in 1705. The verses here are paraphrased.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose one tree near you. Write its rune-poem verse, then write your own verse of the same length.*

## Ash: the world tree

In Grímnismál (Grimnir's sayings), the ash tree Yggdrasill holds up the nine worlds. You can see why when you stand beneath a large one. Its bark is grey and ridged. Its buds are black. Its winged seeds hang in bunches. Its timber is springy and strong, so it was used for spears and tool handles. In the Poetic Edda, Yggdrasill is an ash, and its roots reach to wells where the Nornir (the Norns, who shape fate) sit. Put your palm on the bark. It feels cool and straight.

This tree grows straight. Year after year it adds steady wood, the kind once used for spears and shafts.

Visit one ash in each of the four seasons, and it becomes a familiar friend. Watch the buds open and the birds change above the bark. Walking with one tree through the year gives you a steady place to measure your own growth.

**Where this comes from:** The ash as world-tree is in the Poetic Edda, and ash timber was widely used.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Visit an ash tree this week for twenty minutes, and note where it stands. Return in each season.*

## Birch: bright beginner

Birch leads the spring, with white bark and bright green leaves. It is among the first trees to leaf and among the first to turn gold. Northern farms used its bark for containers and roofing. Coppice workers (people who cut young shoots for reuse) cut birch rods for baskets. One small tree serves many uses. Peel only bark that has already fallen. Never cut a ring around a living trunk, which can kill the tree.

Look closely and you will see why people valued it: light, flexible wood, waterproof bark, and early leaves.

**Where this comes from:** Birch use is known from archaeology and folk life. The birch stanza is in the Anglo-Saxon rune poem.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Find a birch. Note its bark, buds, and leaves, and return in a month to see what changed.*

## Rowan at the threshold

Rowan trees grow near doorways across northern countries. People planted them beside houses and holy wells. Old custom trusted them on doorways, gateposts, and cradles, believing they guarded against harm. It is a small tree with a light crown. Its berries stand scarlet against grey stone. People valued it as a guard more than as timber. Look for rowans near doors as you walk.

In Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, the rowan is called the salvation of Þórr, because Þórr once saved himself from a flooded river by grabbing a rowan on the bank. You can care for a rowan in plain ways: notice it often, take only fallen wood, and never cut a branch without permission.

**Where this comes from:** Rowan at the threshold is folk custom. The rowan as Þórr's salvation is in Snorri's Prose Edda.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find a rowan near a doorway. Note the date, the berries, and where it stands.*

## Yew: the keeper of flame

The yew can outlive the trees around it. It stands dark green through every month, and every part of it is poisonous. In the Grímnismál, Ydalir, "Yew-dales," is the home of Ullr, the archer god, and yew was prized for bows. The Anglo-Saxon rune poem calls the yew "on the outside a rough tree, hard and fast in the earth, a guardian of flame and a joy upon an estate."

Take no teas, no berries, and no experiments. Look, learn the name, and touch nothing. Take nothing away from a yew except notes.

**Where this comes from:** Ydalir is in the Grímnismál in the Poetic Edda. The yew stanza is in the Anglo-Saxon rune poem. The poison is a plain fact.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find a yew near you, or a photograph of one. Note what you see. Do not touch it.*

## Oak: the slow king

Oak measures time in centuries. You feel it when you stand under one. Oaks can stand for hundreds of years, even with hollow trunks. In the north its timber built Viking ships, such as Oseberg and Gokstad, and door posts. The Anglo-Saxon rune poem calls the oak food for pigs and a carrier of ships over the sea.

Put your palm on the bark. It feels ridged, cold, and steady. A lone oak in a field often stands for generations. Guess its girth, the width around the trunk, and note the birds. One oak followed through all four seasons gives your year a steady point to return to.

**Where this comes from:** Viking ships such as Oseberg and Gokstad were built mostly of oak. The oak stanza is in the Anglo-Saxon rune poem.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Walk to one oak this week for twenty minutes, and note how it looks. Return in each season.*

# Liminal Places

Wells that remember

*"All door-ways, before going forward, should be looked to; for difficult it is to know where foes may sit within a dwelling."*

Hávamál, stanza 1, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Wells and the gifts left in them

Bog water and spring water have kept things for a very long time. Long ago, people laid swords, cauldrons, and brooches in lakes, bogs, and springs. Diggers still find them where rivers slow and springs rise. Scholars call these gifts votive deposits, objects given on purpose to a place. In the Vǫluspá, even Óðinn gives to water: he pledged an eye to the well of Mímir for a drink of wisdom. What mattered most was the giving itself.

A well is a place with its own history. It is not a machine that grants wishes. Old deposits are well documented: they were found, lifted from the ground, and recorded. Tossing coins into a living spring is a newer habit, and coins can pollute the water. Never drink wild water, because you cannot know what is in it.

When you visit, go as a guest of the place. Ask leave before you lift any water, and sit a while to listen before you leave. Take nothing away from the site, and leave nothing behind that will not rot or wash clean. Keep any promise you made to the place. The visit takes under an hour.

**Where this comes from:** Old gifts in lakes and springs are found by archaeology. Óðinn's pledge at the well of Mímir is in the Vǫluspá.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name your nearest spring or well, the day you will go, and what you will listen for.*

## Sea roads

For the Old Norse, the sea was a road. In Icelandic sagas, it links farms that could never meet by land. Voyages often begin with vows and end with thanks, and some sagas mention gifts to the sea and wind. A shore belongs to neither farm, and open water is where hard bargains and farewells are made. Promises made on a crossing are held to account: people check whether they were kept.

No shore owns the middle of the water, so every promise made there must be said out loud and kept. Crews name what they leave and what they carry, and they speak their terms while still on the water. To reach the far bank, say your terms plainly and keep them.

Many people now live with an unfinished move, a half-paid house, or a task that was never finished. The old idea of a crossing still helps. Every crossing has a bank behind you and a bank ahead. Say your terms aloud to one witness, as the crews did: one thing you carry over and one thing you set down. The crossing is finished when you keep the terms you set.

**Where this comes from:** Sea-voyage vows appear in Icelandic sagas as a story pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the crossing you are in now: the bank behind you, the bank ahead, what you carry over and what you set down.*

## The door and the guest

The Hávamál begins at a doorway. "All door-ways, before going forward, should be looked to; for difficult it is to know where foes may sit within a dwelling." (Stanza 1, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.) The poem is about what a traveler does at a door, and what a host owes the traveler who arrives.

A host owes a guest what the guest needs. "Fire is needful to him who is come in, and whose knees are frozen; food and raiment a man requires." "Water to him is needful who for refection comes, a towel and hospitable invitation." (Stanzas 3 and 4.) And: "With insult or derision treat thou never a guest or wayfarer." (Stanza 134.)

Keep your own door this way. Look to it before you go out and when you come in. Have water, a towel, warmth, and food ready for whoever arrives, and welcome them plainly. Once a month, look over your doorway: the lock, the light, and the step.

**Where this comes from:** Hávamál stanzas 1 to 4 and 134 in the Poetic Edda, in Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation, now public domain.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Look over the doorway you use most. What would you need to welcome a stranger with water, a towel, warmth, and food?*

## Dawn, dusk, and Yule night

Twice a day, the light is neither fully day nor fully night. Once a year, at Yule (midwinter), the season does something similar. In Icelandic folk belief, the mounds stood open on Yule night and the dead could walk near the living. Dawn and dusk carry a smaller daily version of that opening. The house is quiet, the edges show clearly, and birds wake or settle as the light shifts. Even a city window shows the change.

In old stories, edges were meeting times. People meet at the shore, where land meets water. Bargains were made and messages passed, and dreams carried warnings that guided voyages and killings. Dream warnings are a story device in the sagas, not proof that anyone kept dream books, and this book does not decode dreams. The phrase "thin places" for such spots is modern. Showing up on time at the edge was the offering.

The old practice for keeping an edge is útiseta, sitting out alone at dusk or dawn, described earlier in this book. Take it in the same small and safe way: three dawns or three dusks in a row, ten minutes each, at a window or on a step. Notice the light and count three sounds. If cloud hides the sun, keep the same hour anyway.

Some old northern and Old English texts blame certain sicknesses on outside beings, such as elves (álfar) and the mara, a night-presser who sits on sleepers. This book takes only the habit of watching the edges. It does not diagnose or treat illness. If you are unwell, see a clinician.

**Where this comes from:** Meetings at edges and dream warnings appear in Icelandic sagas as story patterns. The phrase "thin places" is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose dawn or dusk. Sit ten minutes at the same window or step, three days in a row, and note the light and three sounds.*

*Well visit: go, tidy, listen. Write the date, place, what you tidied, what you heard, and what you left.*

# Runes

The letters of the old north

*"Knowest thou how to grave them? knowest thou how to expound them?... knowest thou how to prove them?"*

Hávamál, stanza 146, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## What runes are

Runes are the letters the early Germanic peoples carved in wood, stone, bone, and metal. The oldest inscriptions date from about the second century CE. The alphabet is called the futhark, named for its first six letters: f, u, th, a, r, k. It came in three main forms. The Elder Futhark has 24 runes and was used from about the 2nd to the 8th century. The Younger Futhark has 16 and was used in Viking Age Scandinavia, from about the 9th to the 12th century. The Anglo-Saxon futhorc grew to as many as 33 and was used in England.

Each rune has a name, a sound, and a meaning from the rune poems. Fehu is the sound f and also the word for cattle and wealth. On some inscriptions a single rune stands for the whole word it names, as scholars think the l-rune stands for laukaz, "leek."

The row below is cut on the Kylver stone, a grave slab from Gotland in Sweden, about the year 400. It is the oldest complete futhark we have.

ᚠᚢᚦᚨᚱᚲᚷᚹ ᚺᚾᛁᛃᛇᛈᛉᛊ ᛏᛒᛖᛗᛚᛜᛞᛟ

**Where this comes from:** The Kylver stone and the three futharks are known from archaeology. The rune names come from the rune poems.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Copy the 24 runes of the Kylver row by hand, once, slowly.*

# Vitki: Rune-Reader

A vitki is a person who works with runes. The old word means something close to "wise one." The clearest picture comes from Óðinn himself in the Hávamál. He hangs nine nights in a wind-tossed tree, hungry and thirsty, until he sees the runes below and seizes them with a shout. Then he carves them into wood and reddens the cuts with color.

In the Sigrdrífumál, the valkyrie Sigrdrífa, whom Vǫlsunga saga calls Brynhildr, teaches the hero Sigurðr the same craft. She puts victory runes on the sword hilt, ale runes on the drinking horn, and birth runes on the palm. Knowing here is handwork: you cut, you color, and you speak it aloud.

The medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon) are the alphabet book behind the craft. They hold one short verse for each rune letter, each tied to a plain thing: wealth must move, ice bears no weight, the sun steadies. What they never show is anyone laying runes out to tell fortunes. That is modern and should be called so.

Learn one rune letter a week from the rune poems, and say its verse aloud. The pages that follow give the rows, the names, and how to carve.

**Where this comes from:** The hanging is in the Hávamál, the counsel in the Sigrdrífumál, and the verses in the rune poems, with a parallel in Vǫlsunga saga. Rune-spread divination is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which rune will you learn first this week? Say its name and its verse aloud.*

## Sigrdrífa's runes

In the Sigrdrífumál, the valkyrie Sigrdrífa gives Sigurðr a cup of mead, the minni cup, and then teaches him runes for each need. "Sig-runes thou must know, if victory thou wilt have, and on thy sword's hilt grave them." "Ol- (beer-) runes thou must know... On the horn must they be graven, and on the hand's back." "Biarg- (help-) runes thou must know, if thou wilt help, and loose the child from women. In the palm they must be graven." "Brim- (sea-) runes thou must know, if thou wilt have secure afloat thy sailing steeds. On the prow they must be graven." (Stanzas 6, 7, 9, and 10, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

The list goes on: branch-runes for healers, speech-runes so no one repays you with hate, and thought-runes for wisdom. Each kind of rune is tied to a thing it is cut on: a sword, a horn, a palm, a prow. That is the old pattern. Runes belong on objects, with a purpose, and the cutting is the work.

Notice what is missing. No one lays the runes out to read the future. The Sigrdrífumál is the clearest old list of rune types, and it describes carving, not casting.

Study the list as it stands. Copy one of the quoted stanzas by hand, and note which object it names and what the rune is for.

**Where this comes from:** Sigrdrífumál stanzas 6 to 19 in the Poetic Edda, in Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation, now public domain.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which need of yours has an object to carry it: a tool, a cup, a boat, a door? Name the need and the object.*

## The Elder Futhark: Freyr's eight

The 24 runes are grouped in three families of eight, called ættir (singular ætt). Later books name each family after the rune that begins it: Freyr's ætt, Hagal's ætt, and Týr's ætt. The first is Freyr's.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ᚠ | **fehu** | *f* | cattle, wealth |
| ᚢ | **uruz** | *u* | the aurochs, a wild ox |
| ᚦ | **þurisaz** | *th* | a giant, or a thorn |
| ᚨ | **ansuz** | *a* | a god; the mouth of Óðinn |
| ᚱ | **raidō** | *r* | riding, a journey |
| ᚲ | **kenaz** | *k* | a torch, or a sore |
| ᚷ | **gebō** | *g* | a gift |
| ᚹ | **wunjō** | *w* | joy |

These names are reconstructed. No Elder Futhark inscription records them, so scholars rebuild them from the Anglo-Saxon, Norwegian, and Icelandic rune poems.

**Where this comes from:** The runes are known from inscriptions. Their names are reconstructed from the rune poems.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Say the eight names aloud, then copy the eight runes.*

## The Elder Futhark: Hagal's eight

The second family of eight is called Hagal's ætt, after the hail rune that begins it. Two of its runes, perþō and algiz, have names no one can agree on.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ᚺ | **hagalaz** | *h* | hail |
| ᚾ | **nauðiz** | *n* | need, hardship |
| ᛁ | **īsaz** | *i* | ice |
| ᛃ | **jēra** | *j* | the year, a good harvest |
| ᛇ | **eihwaz** | *ei* | the yew |
| ᛈ | **perþō** | *p* | uncertain; no agreed meaning |
| ᛉ | **algiz** | *z* | uncertain; often read "elk" or "protection" |
| ᛊ | **sōwilō** | *s* | the sun |

**Where this comes from:** The runes are known from inscriptions. Their names are reconstructed from the rune poems.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Say the eight names aloud, then copy the eight runes.*

## The Elder Futhark: Týr's eight

The third family is Týr's ætt, named for the god's rune, tīwaz. It ends with ōþala, the rune of heritage and home.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ᛏ | **tīwaz** | *t* | the god Týr |
| ᛒ | **berkanan** | *b* | the birch |
| ᛖ | **ehwaz** | *e* | a horse |
| ᛗ | **mannaz** | *m* | a man, a person |
| ᛚ | **laguz** | *l* | water; the same rune is also read as laukaz, the leek |
| ᛜ | **ingwaz** | *ng* | the god Ing, a name of Freyr |
| ᛞ | **dagaz** | *d* | day |
| ᛟ | **ōþala** | *o* | an inherited estate, heritage |

**Where this comes from:** The runes are known from inscriptions. Their names are reconstructed from the rune poems.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Say the eight names aloud, then copy the eight runes.*

## The Younger Futhark: sixteen runes

In the Viking Age the row shrank to 16 runes, so each rune had to serve for several sounds. The Icelandic and Norwegian rune poems give each one a short verse. This is the gist of each, in long-branch form.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ᚠ | **fé** | *f* | wealth, which stirs up strife among kin |
| ᚢ | **úr** | *u, o, v* | drizzle or slag |
| ᚦ | **þurs** | *th* | a giant |
| ᚬ | **óss** | *o, a* | a god, "aged Gautr," Óðinn; also a river mouth |
| ᚱ | **reið** | *r* | riding |
| ᚴ | **kaun** | *k, g* | an ulcer, a sore |
| ᚼ | **hagall** | *h* | hail |
| ᚾ | **nauð** | *n* | need, hardship |
| ᛁ | **ís** | *i, e* | ice |
| ᛅ | **ár** | *a, æ* | a good harvest, plenty |
| ᛋ | **sól** | *s* | the sun |
| ᛏ | **týr** | *t, d* | the one-handed god |
| ᛒ | **bjarkan** | *b, p* | the birch |
| ᛘ | **maðr** | *m* | a man |
| ᛚ | **lǫgr** | *l* | water |
| ᛦ | **ýr** | *R* | the yew, a bent bow |

**Where this comes from:** Viking Age stones. The meanings are paraphrased from the Icelandic and Norwegian rune poems (Dickins, 1915).

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Choose three runes and copy each with its name and its poem line.*

## Runes in use: seven examples

**Kylver stone**: the whole futhark, cut on a grave slab on Gotland, about 400.
**Bracteates**: gold medallions from about 500 carry the words alu and laukaz. Nobody is sure what they meant, but they repeat.
**Björketorp stone**: a 7th-century stone in Sweden that curses anyone who breaks it.
**Rök stone**: the longest Viking Age inscription, with some secret runes among the ordinary ones.
**Egill's horn**: in Egils saga, Egill carves runes on a drinking horn and rubs them with blood. The horn bursts, and the poisoned drink spills.
**Egill's whalebone**: in the same saga, a girl is sick because someone carved the wrong runes on a whalebone. Egill scrapes them off, burns the shavings, carves new runes, and she recovers.
**Sigrdrífumál**: the valkyrie Sigrdrífa lists runes for victory, for ale, for birth, for the sea, for healing, for speech, and for wisdom, each cut on a named object.

Egill's verse in the saga sums it up: a man should not carve runes unless he can read them well. Many are confounded by a dark rune.

**Where this comes from:** The inscriptions are known from archaeology. Egill's runes are in Egils saga, and Sigrdrífa's are in the Sigrdrífumál.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these seven would you most like to see in person? Name it and where it is.*

## Writing in runes

To write in runes, spell by sound, not by spelling. The Elder Futhark has no capitals and no rules for spaces. Inscriptions mark the end of a word with a dot or two, and may run left to right or right to left.

| ᚠ | ᛒ | ᛞ | ᛖ | ᚠ | ᚷ | ᚺ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| a | b | d | e | f | g | h |
| ᛁ | ᛃ | ᚲ | ᛚ | ᛗ | ᚾ | ᛟ |
| i | j | k | l | m | n | o |
| ᛈ | ᚱ | ᛊ | ᛏ | ᚢ | ᚹ | ᛉ |
| p | r | s | t | u | w | z |
| | | ᚦ | ᛜ | ᛇ | | |
| | | th | ng | ei | | |

There is no c, v, or y: use ᚲ for c, ᚹ for v, and ᛃ for y. Four examples:

ᛖᚷᛁᛚᛚ ᚦᛟᚱ ᚨᛊᚲ ᛖᛗᛒᛚᚨ

egill thor ask embla

Notice that the runes are all straight lines. Wood has a grain, and a cut along the grain tends to split, so rune strokes run across it. That is one reason runes avoid curves and flat horizontal lines.

**Where this comes from:** The rune values are standard. The grain explanation is the usual scholarly account, not a statement in any source.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write your own name in Elder Futhark, by sound.*

## Carving runes

The old sources say how runes were made. Sigrdrífa tells Sigurðr to carve them on the thing they are for: a sword's hilt, a horn, the palm, a ship's prow. In Egils saga, Egill carves runes and then reddens them with blood. The Hávamál asks the same questions in stanza 146: do you know how to carve a rune, how to read it, how to color it, and how to test it?

To make a simple carved rune, you need a smooth, dry piece of wood and a sharp knife, used carefully and always cutting away from your hand. Draw the runes in pencil first. Cut each stroke across the grain, with two cuts that meet in a V. Then fill the cuts with red ink or paint. This book does not ask for blood.

Egill's rule is the one that matters most: do not carve runes you cannot read. Before you cut a rune, know its name and the sound or word it stands for.

**Where this comes from:** Sigrdrífumál stanzas 6 to 19, Hávamál stanza 146, and Egils saga. The wood and ink steps are practical, not from a source.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Carve one rune you know the name of on a scrap of wood. Fill the cuts with red ink.*

## Bindrunes and secret runes

A bindrune joins two or more runes by sharing one stave, the vertical line. Bindrunes appear on many early and Viking Age inscriptions, to save space or to make a name look like one sign.



fr at

The two signs above join fehu and raidō (fr) and ansuz and tīwaz (at). To make one, pick runes that share a stave, and draw the shared stave once.

Secret runes are older than they sound. The Rök stone uses cipher runes. One old cipher counts the family of eight and the place in the row, so each rune becomes two numbers shown as strokes: fehu is the first rune of the first family, so it is 1 and 1.

**Where this comes from:** Bindrunes and cipher runes are known from Viking Age inscriptions, including the Rök stone.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Join two runes from your own name as a bindrune. Draw it, and write the two runes beside it.*

## Carve your name

The oldest runic sentence formula is a maker's mark. The Golden Horn of Gallehus, made in Denmark about the year 400, carries this line:

ᛖᚲ ᚻᛚᛖᚹᚨᚷᚨᛊᛏᛁᛉ ᚻᛟᛚᛏᛁᛃᚨᛉ ᚻᛟᚱᚾᚨ ᛏᚨᚹᛁᛞᛟ

It reads "ek Hlewagastiz Holtijaz horna tawido," which means "I, Hlewagastiz, son of Holt, made the horn." The golden horns were stolen and melted in 1802, but drawings of the inscription survive.

Use the same pattern on something you have made. Write ek, then your name, then tawido, which means "made." Spell by sound, and carve it as you learned on the last pages.

**Where this comes from:** The Gallehus inscription is known from early drawings. The formula ek ... tawido recurs on other early inscriptions.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Carve ek, your name, and tawido on something you have made.*

## A rune a day

The oldest complete rune row we have is on the Kylver stone from Gotland, carved about the year 400. It lists the whole Elder Futhark in order, and it is the earliest full row we have. You can use that order as a month-long practice, one rune a day for twenty-four days.

Each day, take the next rune from the three groups of eight on the earlier pages. Say its name aloud. Read its line in the rune poems. Draw it three times in your notebook, then carve it once if you have wood and a knife. Spend one more minute looking for the thing it names: cattle, water, ice, a gift, a day. Five minutes is enough.

At the end of the twenty-four days, write your name in the runes you have learned, and say which three felt most like yours. Egill's rule still holds. Do not use a rune you cannot name.

**Where this comes from:** The order of the Elder Futhark comes from the Kylver stone, about 400 CE. The daily practice was built for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Pick the day you will start. Write the first rune, its name, and one thing you noticed about it.*

## Casting lots

The Roman writer Tacitus, writing about 98 CE, describes how Germanic peoples took omens. They cut a branch from a fruit tree into small slips and cut a mark on each one. The slips were scattered on a white cloth. A priest, or in a private matter the father of the household, prayed to the gods, looked up at the sky, and lifted three slips one at a time. He read them by the marks. If the lots forbade a plan, it was dropped for that day.

Tacitus says marks, not runes, so we cannot say these were runes. What this shows is that drawing marked slips for a yes-or-no answer was an old habit. Rune casting as it is practiced now, with named meanings and layouts, is modern.

To try the old shape, gather ten or more small pieces of wood from fallen twigs, and cut a rune you know on each. Lay out a light cloth. Ask a question about something you can actually do. Pull three slips, one at a time, without looking. Read each by its name and its poem line. Then decide what you will do. The runes give you something to think with, not an order.

**Where this comes from:** Tacitus, Germania, chapter 10. The runes, the question, and the reading method are modern.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Draw three slips for a choice you face this week. Write each rune, its name, and what you decided.*

*Rune notebook: write each rune you carve, its name, its poem line, and where you used it.*

# Staves

use them honestly

*"Brim- (sea-) runes thou must know, if thou wilt have secure afloat thy sailing steeds."*

Sigrdrífumál, stanzas 6 to 10, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Runes and staves are not the same

Runes are an alphabet. They were cut from about the 2nd to the 12th century, for writing and for magic, and their names and meanings are in the rune poems.

Galdrastafir, usually called staves, are magic signs. They come from Iceland, mostly from the 15th to the 19th centuries, and they were drawn in charm books beside Latin, runes, and Christian prayers. A stave is not a letter. It is a sign made for a purpose.

That difference matters because many modern sellers call staves Viking symbols. They are not. The staves in this chapter are medieval and early modern, and the pages say when each one is from.

**Where this comes from:** The dating is from the Icelandic manuscripts described on the next page.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Say in one sentence how a rune differs from a stave.*

## The stave books: a timeline

**About 1500, AM 434 a 12mo**: an Icelandic book of medicine and magic. Its staves are drawn beside remedies, and its rituals are for finding a thief, frightening an enemy, and avoiding a ruler's anger.
**1600s, Galdrabók**: a collection of Icelandic spells that mixes Latin, runes, and staves with Christian prayers.
**1670, Galdrakver**: "the little magic book," a small skin-bound book. Its drawings include the sign called the Helm of Awe.
**1860s, the Huld manuscript**: a 19th-century collection that holds the way-pointer, Vegvísir.

Dates are approximate, and scholars disagree on some of them. The oldest manuscript is already two to three centuries after the Viking Age.

**Where this comes from:** Luthien Cangemi's The Art of Healing in Medieval Iceland (UCL, 2024) for AM 434 a 12mo, and standard descriptions of the other books.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these four books would you most like to see? Name it and why.*

## Three rituals from the oldest stave book

**To see a thief.** Carve a sign on the bottom of a box. Grind yarrow as fine as you can in clean water, and say: "I desire, by the nature of the herb and the power of the sign, that I may see the shadow of the one who has stolen from me." End with the Latin words In nomine domini, amen.

**To frighten an enemy.** Pick yarrow on the feast of Bishop John. Keep the sun off it, take it with all its roots, and speak over it when the sun is in the south-east. Carry the sign in your left hand.

**To avoid a ruler's anger.** Go out before sunrise and speak to no one. Take yarrow and let your blood fall on it, then draw a cross on your forehead with the herb, and go before your lord.

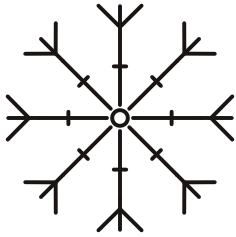
Notice the pattern: a sign, a herb, spoken words, and a Christian closing. These rituals are quoted as history. This book does not ask you to draw blood or to try them.

**Where this comes from:** AM 434 a 12mo, as quoted in Luthien Cangemi's thesis, from Ben Waggoner's translation.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of the three rituals is the strangest to you, and why?*

## Two famous staves

**Ægishjálmr**, the Helm of Awe, takes its name from the Fáfnismál, where the dragon Fáfnir says: "An Oegis-helm I bore among the sons of men, while I o'er the treasures lay." (Stanza 16, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.) Sigurðr answers that it is no protection when angry men fight. One 17th-century stave book describes the Helm of Awe as a sign to carve in lead and press between the brows to overcome foes. The drawing below is a simplified modern version; the manuscripts vary.



**Vegvísir**, the way-pointer, is from the 19th-century Huld manuscript. It says that a person who carries the sign will not lose their way in storms or bad weather, even on an unknown road. It is not a Viking Age sign.

**Where this comes from:** The Fáfnismál is in the Poetic Edda. The Helm of Awe instructions are in 17th-century Icelandic stave books, and Vegvísir is in the Huld manuscript.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these two staves would you want on a journey? Say why.*

## Valknútr (Valknut) is old; the rest is newer



The valknútr (knot of the slain) is three triangles locked together. It is cut on Viking Age picture stones beside riders and ships. Its link to Óðinn is only suggested, by the scenes it appears in, not by a written label.

Of the signs in this chapter, only the valknútr is Viking Age. The staves are later. The triquetra, a knot of three pointed loops, belongs to Early Christian and medieval art, and most tangled knotwork sold as a Viking badge is medieval or modern craft.

Study it where it was found. Find photographs of Viking Age picture stones that show a valknútr, and sketch the knot. Beside each sketch, note the scene around it: riders, ships, or fallen warriors.

**Where this comes from:** The valknútr is cut on Viking Age picture stones. The triquetra comes from Christian and medieval art.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sketch a valknútr from a photograph of a picture stone. Note the scene around it.*

# Galdr: Charms

Words in old books

*"For the fourth I know, if men place bonds on my limbs, I so sing that I can walk; the fetter starts from my feet..."*

Hávamál, stanzas 150 and 151, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Galdr: the sung charm

A charm is a short set of words said or sung for a purpose. A galdr is a charm that is sung or spoken aloud, not one thought in silence. In the Hávamál, Óðinn lists the songs he knows, the way a carpenter lists tools, and each one has its work named: one blunts an enemy's blade, another loosens chains from the wrists, and so on. The Sigrdrífumál shows the same pattern in a smaller way, when the valkyrie Sigrdrífa teaches Sigurðr rune songs for sword, ale, and healing.

The voice is the teaching. No tune survives in the Poetic Edda. The Hávamál gives purposes and boasts, never notes on a staff. Any modern galdr with set tunes, robes, and staged circle work is a modern rebuilding, and it is honest when called so.

The Sigrdrífumál does give one short spoken prayer: "Hail to Day! Hail to the sons of Day! To Night and her daughter hail! With placid eyes behold us here, and here sitting give us victory. Hail to the Æsir! Hail to the Asyniur! Hail to the bounteous earth! Words and wisdom give to us noble twain, and healing hands while we live." (Stanzas 3 and 4, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.) Learn it by heart and speak it aloud at the same window three mornings in a row.

**Where this comes from:** The charm list is in the Hávamál and the prayer is in the Sigrdrífumál, both in the Poetic Edda, in Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation, now public domain. No tunes survive.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Learn Sigrdrífa's prayer by heart and speak it aloud at the same window three mornings in a row.*

## Óðinn's songs

At the end of the Hávamál, Óðinn lists eighteen songs he knows and says what each one does. "For the third I know, if I have great need to restrain my foes, the weapons' edge I deaden." "For the fourth I know, if men place bonds on my limbs, I so sing that I can walk; the fetter starts from my feet, and the manacle from my hands." (Stanzas 150 and 151, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

Other songs help against strife and cares, still a fire in a house, calm the wind and sea for a boat, end hatred among people, and keep warriors safe in battle. The list is a catalogue of needs, and each song answers one.

Óðinn does not give the words. No tune and no verse of any song survives. He does say something about giving: "'Tis better not to pray than too much offer; a gift ever looks to a return." (Stanza 147.) Know what you need before you speak, and do not give more than you can spare.

Read stanzas 148 to 165 across a week, one song a night. Choose the song whose need is nearest to yours, and write that need in one line.

**Where this comes from:** Hávamál stanzas 146 to 166 in the Poetic Edda, in Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation, now public domain.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of Óðinn's songs answers a need you have right now? Name the song and the need.*

## Níð: words as weapons

The old Norse feared words. A curse could be spoken, carved, or raised on a pole. The best-known case is in Egils saga. Egill, wronged by King Eiríkr and Queen Gunnhildr, sets a hazel pole on a rocky height facing the mainland and fixes a horse's head on it. He speaks his curse aloud, calling on the land-spirits to wander lost until the king and queen are driven out, and he cuts it in runes on the pole. It is called a níðstǫng, a scorn pole.

Curses were carved in stone too. The Björketorp stone in Sweden threatens anyone who breaks it. Icelandic law punished níð, the shaming of a person with insulting verse or carved insult, as a serious crime.

This book does not give you a curse to use. The old texts show that curses were aimed at powerful wrongdoers, taken seriously, and risky for the speaker. If anger needs somewhere to go, write it on paper and say it once, alone. Then tear the page up or burn it safely.

**Where this comes from:** Egils saga and the Björketorp stone. The laws against níð are in the Icelandic law code Grágás. The advice on writing out anger is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What is one thing you want to say but will not say aloud? Write it, then decide what to do with the page.*

## The Merseburg charms

The Merseburg charms are two short spoken charms in Old High German, the old language of southern Germany. They were copied into a church book in the 900s, and they are among the very few pagan Germanic charms to survive in verse. Both open with a short story, then give a command.

In the first, women called idisi sit down. Some bind a captive, some hold back an army, and some pick at the fetters. The charm ends with the words: "Leap out of the bonds, escape the enemies."

In the second, Wodan, the southern form of Óðinn, and other gods ride into a wood, and Balder's foal sprains its foot. Wodan, who knew the charms well, sets it right: "bone to bone, blood to blood, limb to limb, as if they were glued."

Notice the shape: a story about gods or spirits, then the words that copy what they did. That is the old pattern for a spoken charm. This book offers no cure, and if you are ill you should see a clinician.

**Where this comes from:** The Merseburg charms are in a church manuscript from the 900s, in Old High German. The summaries and quoted lines here are in plain English.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Retell one of the two charms in your own words. Underline its story and its command.*

# Ancestors

Mound-neighbors

*"...but I know one thing that never dies, judgement on each one dead."*

Hávamál, stanza 77, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Mound-neighbors

Low green mounds in the fields are old burial places. Haugr, the burial mound, stands in Icelandic sagas as the home of the dead. In some sagas the dead keep watch over cattle and weather, and gifts are laid and words spoken at mounds. The Sigrdrífumál tells the living to care for the dead: "Let a mound be raised for those departed; let their hands and head be washed, combed, and wiped dry." (Stanza 34, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

The Hávamál says what lasts: "Cattle die, kindred die, we ourselves also die; but the fair fame never dies of him who has earned it." (Stanza 76.) Mounds and ship-settings, stone outlines shaped like ships, are found by archaeologists, and you can visit them. The talking dead come from Icelandic sagas, which is a story pattern, not a map.

A name can be honored with no ritual at all. Speak it, and remember one true thing. Fuller remembrance is on the next page. There is no test. Speak a name and be kind.

**Where this comes from:** Mounds appear in Icelandic sagas and in archaeology. The quoted stanzas are from the Sigrdrífumál and the Hávamál.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Rest with one name tonight. Say it aloud and write one true sentence about the person.*

## Waking the dead

The old poems know the dead can be woken. In the Hervararkviða, Hervǫr sails to an island of burial mounds. At night, with fire burning over the mounds, she stands before her father Angantýr's mound and calls him up. She asks for the sword that lies buried with him. He warns her away, and she does not back down. At last he gives it to her.

In the Grógaldr, a young man named Svipdagr stands at his dead mother Gróa's mound and asks her to wake and sing him charms for a hard road. She sings nine of them.

Both scenes follow one pattern: go to the mound, call the dead by name, and ask for one clear thing. In both, the dead may warn you or refuse, and the living need nerve and a good reason.

A modern way to follow the pattern does not need a graveyard or darkness. Sit with a grave, a photograph, or something that belonged to the person. Say their name aloud. Ask for one thing: advice, strength, or a story. Then be quiet and listen. Thank them, and leave something small. The dead may not answer in words.

**Where this comes from:** The Hervararkviða is in Hervarar saga ok Heiðreks. The Grógaldr is the first poem of the Svipdagsmál, kept in later paper manuscripts. The practice above is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Who would you call, and what is the one thing you would ask? Write the name and the question.*

## The memorial toast

The Old Norse remembered the dead with a feast. After a death, kin gathered for the funeral feast, called the erfi. In Ynglinga saga, an heir did not take his father's seat until he had drunk the bragarfull, a special cup, and made a vow. Then he sat in the high seat. In Hákonar saga góða, toasts were drunk to the memory of departed kin. Such a toast was called a minni.

Keep the shape at your table. Serve a plain, hot meal, including a dish they used to make. Before the meal, each person names the dead in turn, with one true sentence. Then raise a cup and drink to their memory. That is the minni. As in the old feast, follow the toast with a vow: one thing you will do in their honor.

Once a year is plenty, at Yule or Winter Nights. If it is your family's custom, set one extra plate, a later folk habit. Leave a little food out for birds the next morning. Steady remembrance matters more than grandeur. Tears are fine.

**Where this comes from:** The funeral feast, the bragarfull, and the minni toast are in Ynglinga saga and Hákonar saga góða in Snorri's Heimskringla. The extra plate is later folk custom.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

*Choose the menu and the names, and hold the supper at Yule or Winter Nights. Write your vow.*

*Ancestor card, first: write the name, dates, one story, one thing they left you, and one question.*

*Grief letter and roll call: write a letter you will not send, then list the names you will speak at Yule.*

# Oath

Go on reading

*"That no oath thou swear, if it be not true. Cruel bonds follow broken faith..."*

Sigrdrífumál, stanza 23, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866

## Hávamál: friends and gifts

The Hávamál has a great deal to say about friendship, and it is practical. "Long is and indirect the way to a bad friend's, though by the road he dwell; but to a good friend's the paths lie direct, though he be far away." (Stanza 34, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

Friends trade gifts and visits. "With arms and vestments friends should each other gladden... Givers and requiters are longest friends, if all [else] goes well." (Stanza 41.) "If thou hast a friend whom thou fully trustest... thou shouldst blend thy mind with his, and gifts exchange, and often go to see him." (Stanza 44.) The poem is also honest about friends you do not trust: be pleasant, but guard your thoughts.

This is advice from a world with no safety net, where a friend meant a roof, a meal, and an ally at the assembly. Give one friend a small gift this month, and visit them. The old rule is that gifts are returned and visits are repaid.

**Where this comes from:** Hávamál stanzas 34 to 46 in the Poetic Edda, in Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation, now public domain.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which friend's road is direct for you? Name them, and give them a small gift or a visit this month.*

## Sigrdrífa's counsel

In the Sigrdrífumál, the valkyrie Sigrdrífa gives Sigurðr eleven pieces of counsel before he rides on. She numbers them: this I counsel first, this I counsel secondly, and so on. They are the nearest thing the Poetic Edda has to a code for living.

Among them: be blameless toward your kin, and take no hasty vengeance (the first). Swear no oath that is not true, for "cruel bonds follow broken faith: accursed is the faith-breaker" (the second). Do not argue with a fool in the assembly (the third). Do not quarrel when drunk, for "wine steals the wits of many" (the sixth). Bury the dead you find, and raise them a mound (the ninth). Do not trust a promise from the kin of a man you have wronged (the tenth). (Stanzas 22 to 35, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

Some of her counsel, about enemies and women, belongs to its own time. This book keeps the parts that still help: keep faith with your kin, keep your oaths, keep your head, and care for the dead.

Choose one counsel to follow this month. Write it on the vow page that follows.

**Where this comes from:** Sigrdrífumál stanzas 22 to 37 in the Poetic Edda, in Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation, now public domain.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of Sigrdrífa's counsels do you most need? Copy it and say why.*

*Your vow page: fill it in. I will keep ___ for 30 days. I will not ___. Witnessed by ___.*

# Books behind this book

**Primary sources, in translation**

The Poetic Edda — trans. Carolyne Larrington, or trans. Jackson Crawford (Hackett, 2015).

Snorri Sturluson, The Prose Edda — trans. Anthony Faulkes.

Benjamin Thorpe, Edda of Sæmund the Learned (1866) — public domain, quoted on several pages.

Vǫlsunga Saga (The Saga of the Vǫlsungs) — trans. Jesse Byock; trans. Jackson Crawford.

Egils saga — in translation.

The rune poems: Norwegian, Icelandic, Anglo-Saxon — in translation.

**Witnesses, histories, law**

Tacitus, Germania; Ibn Fadlan, account of the Rus burial on the Volga.

Adam of Bremen, Gesta Hammaburgensis Ecclesiae Pontificum.

Landnámabók; Grágás (the Grey Goose Laws).

Sigvatr Þórðarson, Austrfararvísur.

Ynglinga Saga; the Merseburg Charms; Old English leechbooks.

**Scholarship and teaching**

Jackson Crawford — YouTube channel: Norse mythology, language, sagas, and culture.

Luthien Cangemi — The Art of Healing in Medieval Iceland, PhD thesis, UCL, 2024.

Ben Waggoner — Norse Magical and Herbal Healing: A Medical Book from Medieval Iceland (The Troth, 2011).

Carl-Herman Tillhagen — Swedish folk custom records.

## Go on reading

Four old texts go further into this subject. Read small parts in public translations before you buy anything. The Poetic Edda in Larrington's translation opens with the seeress and the counsel of Hávamál. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda in Faulkes's version tells the stories plainly. The Vǫlsunga Saga in Byock's translation follows Sigurðr to the pyre. Egils saga tells of a poem that buys back Egill's own head in York. Borrow them first, so you can judge them fairly.

Read these books first as stories, and second as lessons. They are original old texts, in translation, not summaries. They reward slow reading. For each part, ask what happened, what it means at home, and what small act answers it. Let the answer settle over a week. A chapter a week is a good pace. Keep a notebook beside you, and write your answers there.

Start with one book and one starting day. The next morning, sit in the same spot and read the next section. An hour or less per sitting is plenty. Pick a time that suits you and keep it. When you finish, pass the book on, and mark the page that held you longest. Keeping to your reading plan is a small vow you can keep.

**Where this comes from:** The primary texts to read next. Go meet them.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Commit to one book and one starting day. Mark the page that holds you longest.*

# Words in this book

**Æsir**: the main family of gods, led by Óðinn.
**Vanir**: the older family of gods of harvest and plenty.
**jǫtnar**: giants.
**Nornir**: the women who shape fate.
**dísir**: female guardian spirits of a family.
**landvættir**: land spirits, the guardians of a place.
**valkyrie**: a chooser of the slain.
**einherjar**: warriors who feast in Valhǫll.
**blót**: an offering feast, a gift to gods or spirits.
**minni**: a toast to the memory of the dead.
**erfi**: a funeral feast.
**galdr**: a charm sung or spoken aloud.
**seiðr**: fate-magic, mostly practiced by women.
**vǫlva**: a seeress who carries a staff.
**vitki**: a rune-worker, a wise one.
**hamingja**: personal luck, built by conduct.
**útiseta**: sitting out alone at night to seek counsel.
**haugr**: a burial mound.
**skald**: a court poet.
**saga**: an Icelandic prose story.
**Edda**: the Poetic Edda, a book of poems, and Snorri's Prose Edda.
**Ragnarǫk**: the end of the world and its renewal.

**Where this comes from:** Standard meanings of these Old Norse words, as the sources use them.